

THE HIGH NORTH: HOW U.S. ARCTIC STRATEGY IMPACTS HOMELAND SECURITY

HEARING BEFORE THE COMMITTEE ON HOMELAND SECURITY HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES ONE HUNDRED EIGHTEENTH CONGRESS FIRST SESSION

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THE HIGH NORTH: HOW U.S. ARCTIC STRATEGY IMPACTS HOMELAND SECURITY

Wednesday, November 29, 2023

U.S. HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES,
COMMITTEE ON HOMELAND SECURITY,
WASHINGTON, DC.

The committee met, pursuant to notice, at 10:08 a.m., in room 310, Cannon House Office Building, Hon. Mark Green [Chairman of the committee] presiding.

Present: Representatives Green, Higgins, Gimenez, Pfluger, Gonzales, Ezell, D'Esposito, Strong, Brecheen, Crane, Thompson, Correa, Carter, Thanedar, Ivey, Goldman, Garcia, Menendez, Clarke, and Titus.

Chairman GREEN. The Committee on Homeland Security will come to order. Without objection, the Chair may declare the committee in recess at any point. The purpose of this hearing is to receive testimony on the present and future challenges in the Arctic region and evaluate the United States Coast Guard's unique role in maintaining freedom of movement, defending vital U.S. national interests, and protecting U.S. sovereignty in the region. I now recognize myself for an opening statement.

The United States faces a world fraught with peril. We have an unprecedented crisis at our Southwest Border. Israel, our closest ally in the Middle East, endured the deadliest attack on Jews since the Holocaust. Russia's on-going and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine is the largest armed conflict in Europe since World War II. East Asia is on a hair trigger because of the expansionist tendencies of the Chinese Communist Party in the South China Sea.

So, you might be asking, why is the Committee on Homeland Security having a hearing about the Arctic? In Congress, our daily business is often dictated by the latest disaster or most recent crisis, and to be sure, there are plenty of those. However, during my time in the military and beginning at West Point, of course, I was taught to view the battlefield through a strategic lens and step back from the tactical situation to examine the whole of the operating environment. In this spirit, I believe it is time for the committee to examine the strategic and critical role of the Arctic region.

The story of how the United States became an Arctic nation explains why the Arctic matters so much to us. In 1867, Secretary of State William Seward secured a treaty with the Russian Tsar Alexander II for the purchase of Alaska from the Russian empire for a modest \$7.2 million. Many U.S. Senators were skeptical of Seward's vision when the treaty arrived in the Senate for ratifica-

tion. However, the Chairman of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, Senator Charles Sumner, ushered the treaty through his committee, helping to secure its ratification. In his research, Sumner realized both the economic potential of Alaska's bountiful natural resources and the territory's strategic geographic position to the shipping routes of Asia.

Nearly seven decades later, the founding father of the United States Air Force, Billy Mitchell, declared in testimony to Congress, and I quote, "I believe that in the future, whoever controls Alaska controls the world. I think it is the most strategic place in the world." Mitchell's vision for the eventual 49th State proved shrewd.

The United States Air Force based early warning radar stations, long-range bombers, and missile defense capabilities in Alaska during the Cold War due to its proximity to the Soviet Union. Passenger airlines also utilized Alaska as the global hub, so planes from Western Europe, East Asia, and North America could avoid traveling through restricted Soviet airspace.

Today, nearly 150 years since the purchase of Alaska, the world has changed dramatically. Not surprisingly, though, the Alaskan Arctic remains strategically vital to the United States. The airspace in Alaska is the United States' first line of defense against intrusions by aircraft or missiles, as was brazenly reminded earlier this year with a surveillance balloon. U.S. military forces based in Alaska stand ready to deploy quickly to any theater of operations in the world, from Eastern Europe, the Middle East, the Western Pacific.

As the sea ice recedes and the waters of the Arctic Ocean become traversable for longer stretches of the year, civilian and military maritime traffic has increased. This trend will only make Alaska even more strategically important to the United States as Alaska lies at the confluence of the two major shipping routes through the Arctic to East Asia the Northern Sea Route and the Northwest Passage. Our geopolitical adversaries recognize that control of the Arctic region is essential.

Russia, which has the most territory and largest Arctic population, maintains a robust military presence in the region. Russia has six icebreakers. The United States currently has two. Russia's proximity to Alaska makes its concentration of forces appear even more menacing. The Russian mainland lies less than 60 miles away from the west coast of Alaska. Additionally, just 2.4 miles separate the Russian island of Diomedes and the American island of Little Diomedes in the Bering Strait. To make matters worse, the People's Republic of China has absurdly claimed itself to be "a near-Arctic State" and is attempting to impose its will through diplomatic pressure and increasing maritime transits by PRC vessels in Arctic waters. The PRC is also actively building out its own icebreaker fleet, and its two existing icebreakers have operated in both the Arctic and Antarctic regions.

Therefore, the United States must prioritize the Arctic as a region of National importance and one that is vital to our homeland security, and this committee has a crucial role to play in securing our strategic interest in the Arctic. The United States Coast Guard has operated in Alaska since the United States purchased the State. Today, with its icebreaker fleet and assets based

around Alaska, the Coast Guard is a critical component of the U.S. National security posture in the Arctic, performing search-and-rescue operations in austere environments, and enforcing U.S. laws in our waters off the coasts of Alaska.

As maritime traffic increases, we must ensure that the Coast Guard maintains the ability to protect our coastline, enforce our laws, and save lives at sea. The Department of Homeland Security has a responsibility to protect our transportation sector and critical infrastructure from physical and cyber threats. Alaska hosts a multitude of important military bases and critical infrastructure sites, sites such as the Trans Alaska Pipeline, the Port of Alaska, and Ted Stevens International Airport, in addition to several military installations in Alaska and critical undersea cables connecting Alaska to the continental United States.

It is vital that the Department of Homeland Security work to deter potential attacks or attempts by adversaries to degrade or disrupt the operations of this critical infrastructure. Secretary Seward, Senator Sumner, and Colonel Mitchell recognized the enormous potential of Alaska in their time. We must not lose sight of their prescient vision in our time.

[The statement of Chairman Green follows:]

STATEMENT OF CHAIRMAN MARK E. GREEN

The United States faces a world fraught with peril.

We have an unprecedented crisis at our Southwest Border with illegal immigrants crossing at an average pace of 8,000 per day, overwhelming our border security apparatus and inflicting a severe toll on the U.S. economy.

Israel—our closest ally in the Middle East—endured the deadliest attack on Jews since the Holocaust, and its on-going war against Iranian-backed terrorists is threatening to send the entire region into a conflict.

Russia's on-going and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine is the largest armed conflict in Europe since World War II.

East Asia is on a hair-trigger because of the expansionist tendencies of the Chinese Communist Party in the South China Sea and throughout the region.

So, you might be asking, why is the Committee on Homeland Security having a hearing about the Arctic?

In Congress, our daily business is often dictated by the latest disaster or most recent crisis—and to be sure, there are plenty of crises.

However, during my time at West Point, I was taught to view the battlefield through a strategic lens and step back from the tactical situation to examine the whole operating environment.

In this spirit, I believe it is time for the committee to examine the strategic and critical role of the Arctic region.

The story of how the United States became an Arctic nation explains why the Arctic matters so much.

In 1867, Secretary of State William Seward secured a treaty with Russian Tsar Alexander the Second for the purchase of Alaska from the Russian Empire for a modest \$7.2 million.

Many U.S. Senators were skeptical of Seward's vision when the Treaty arrived in the Senate for ratification.

However, the Chairman of the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, Senator Charles Sumner, ushered the Treaty through his committee, helping to secure ratification.

In his research, Sumner realized both the economic potential of Alaska's bountiful natural resources and the territory's strategic geographic position to the shipping routes of Asia.

Nearly seven decades later, the founding father of the U.S. Air Force, Billy Mitchell, declared in testimony to Congress, "I believe that in the future, whoever controls Alaska controls the world. I think it is the most strategic place in the world."

Mitchell's vision for the eventual 49th State proved shrewd.

The U.S. Air Force based early warning radar stations, long-range bombers, and missile defense capabilities in Alaska during the Cold War due to its proximity to the Soviet Union.

Passenger airlines also utilized Alaska as a global hub so planes from Western Europe, East Asia, and North America could avoid traveling through restricted Soviet airspace.

Today, nearly 150 years since the purchase of Alaska, the world has changed dramatically.

Not surprisingly, though, the Alaskan Arctic remains strategically vital to the United States.

The airspace in Alaska is the United States' first line of defense against intrusions by aircraft or missiles, as we were brazenly reminded earlier this year with the Chinese aerial surveillance balloon.

U.S. military forces based in Alaska stand ready to deploy quickly to any theater of operations in the world, from Eastern Europe and the Middle East to the Western Pacific.

As the sea ice recedes and the waters of the Arctic Ocean become traversable for longer stretches of the year, civilian and military maritime traffic has increased significantly in the region.

This trend will only make Alaska more strategically important to the United States, as Alaska lies at the confluence of the two major shipping routes through the Arctic to East Asia—the Northern Sea Route and the Northwest Passage.

Our geopolitical adversaries recognize that control of the Arctic region is essential.

Russia, which has the most territory and largest Arctic population, maintains a robust military presence in the region. Russia has 6 icebreakers whereas the United States currently has 2.

Russia's proximity to Alaska makes its concentration of forces appear even more menacing.

The Russian mainland lies less than 60 miles away from the west coast of Alaska.

Additionally, just 2.4 miles separate the Russian island of Big Diomedes and the American island of Little Diomedes in the Bering Strait.

To make matters worse, the People's Republic of China has absurdly claimed itself to be a "near-Arctic State," and is attempting to impose its will through diplomatic pressure and increasing maritime transits by PRC vessels in Arctic waters.

The PRC is also actively building out its own icebreaker fleet, and its two existing icebreakers have operated in both the Arctic and Antarctic regions.

Therefore, the United States must prioritize the Arctic as a region of National importance and one that is vital to our homeland security.

And this committee has a crucial role to play in securing our strategic interests in the Arctic.

The United States Coast Guard has operated in Alaska since the the United States purchased the State.

Today, with its icebreaker fleet and assets based around Alaska, the Coast Guard is a critical component of the U.S. national security posture in the Arctic, performing search-and-rescue operations in austere environments and enforcing U.S. laws in our waters off the coast of Alaska.

As maritime traffic increases, we must ensure that the Coast Guard maintains the ability to protect our coastline, enforce our laws, and save lives at sea.

The Department of Homeland Security has a responsibility to protect our transportation sector and critical infrastructure from physical or cyber threats.

Alaska hosts a multitude of important military bases and critical infrastructure sites. Sites such as the Trans-Alaska Pipeline, the Port of Alaska, and Ted Stevens International Airport—in addition to several military installations in Alaska and critical undersea cables connecting Alaska to the continental United States—are crucial to our economy.

It is vital that the Department of Homeland Security works to deter potential attacks or attempts by adversaries to degrade or disrupt the operation of this critical infrastructure.

Secretary Seward, Senator Sumner, and Colonel Mitchell recognized the enormous potential of Alaska in their time.

We must not lose sight of their prescient vision in our time.

I thank our witnesses for appearing before the committee today, and I look forward to their testimonies.

Chairman GREEN. I thank our witnesses for appearing before the committee today, and I look forward to their testimonies.

The purpose, of course, our hearing today, as I said, is to address the issues of opportunity and threat that the Arctic region poses. I am going to defer the Ranking Member's statements until he arrives.

I would now like to introduce our distinguished panel of witnesses. Questions by Members on the dais will be reserved for the witnesses on the second panel after the opening statement from our first panel. Senator Dan Sullivan has represented the State of Alaska since 2015. Senator, thank you for being here today, and I now recognize you for 5 minutes of an opening statement.

**STATEMENT OF HON. DAN SULLIVAN, A SENATOR IN
CONGRESS FROM THE STATE OF ALASKA**

Mr. SULLIVAN. Thank you, Chairman Green and Ranking Member Thompson. I am very honored to be able to testify on this important hearing on the Arctic and Arctic strategy. I commend the committee. To your point, Mr. Chairman, there is a lot going on in the world, but we got to keep our eye on all strategic areas of the globe and America's interests. So, I commend the committee for undertaking this hearing to understand the complexities of Arctic security and providing me an opportunity to talk about the increasing significance of the Arctic region to our Nation's security.

The Arctic, as you mentioned in your excellent opening statement, and by the way, you are going to hear some repetition here, because I think it was so good, but the Arctic is undergoing monumental changes. Sea ice is receding, opening an entire ocean that was previously unreachable. This allows access to a wealth of natural resources and makes available maritime trade routes that are thousands of nautical miles shorter than transits using the Suez Canal or Panama Canal. The strategic importance of this region, the Arctic, is unquestionable.

Arctic security is American security. Despite that, we as a country are not properly postured to secure our vital National interests in this region. America is an Arctic nation because of Alaska. Mr. Chairman, I appreciated a little bit of the history on my great State. By the way, \$7.2 million, probably the best real estate deal in the history of America. Maybe the Louisiana Purchase, but they are both close. Two cents an acre.

My State is at the forefront of Arctic competition and guards the United States against threats from our competitors. We all know, and you mentioned it, Mr. Chairman, we are in a new era of authoritarian aggression led by the dictators Vladimir Putin and Xi Jinping. They are running hostile regimes that seek to control access to the Arctic region and importantly and dangerously, are increasingly working together in the Arctic. Alaska's proximity to both Russia and China requires that my State play a vital role in securing America's interests in the Arctic.

You mentioned Billy Mitchell. I never tire, my colleagues on the Armed Services Committee get a little bit tired of the quote, but I'll say it again since you already said it. Billy Mitchell referred to in a hearing in the Congress as Alaska is the most strategic place in the world. Fortunately, we have undertaken a military build-up there that needs to continue. Right now, Alaska constitutes three pillars of America's military might. We are the cornerstone of mis-

sile defense for the entire country. All the radar systems and all the ground-based missile interceptors are based in Alaska, protecting every city in the United States. We are the hub of air combat power for the Arctic in the INDOPACOM region, for example, we have over 100 5th-generation fighters located in Alaska, F-22s and F-35s. There is no place on the planet Earth that has over 100 combat-coded 5th-gen fighters.

To your point, Mr. Chairman, we are the platform for expeditionary forces, including the Army's new 11th Airborne Division, that can deploy on a moment's notice anywhere in the entire Northern Hemisphere. But we need to make sure that Alaska becomes the logistical hub for the Arctic, for our power projection in the Arctic. In recent years, the Russian Navy has stepped up the scale of its exercises near Alaska. It is doing all kinds of bare bomber runs at our State. They are so common that they don't even make the news anymore. Several already this year. Last year, Russia and China, for the first time deployed a joint naval task force, 7 ships to Alaska's waters. We responded. I love the Coast Guard, but we responded with one small Coast Guard cutter. I called some of our senior military and Coast Guard leaders saying, look, this is going to continue. If it happens again, we need to show a much stronger, robust approach. You may have read this summer, it happened again. This time, 11 Russian and Chinese ships operating off the coast of Alaska. To our military NORTHCOM and INDOPACOM's credit, they sent four destroyers and P-8s to track this very significant joint Russian-Chinese naval task force.

But we must make sure that this is a sign of things to come. We not only need more Coast Guard assets, but also a Navy presence back in Alaska. We will need to be able to respond more rapidly in the future to these kind of incursions. Unfortunately, and I love our Department of Defense, the DoD has been asleep at the switch on the Arctic. The leaders on these issues have been the House and the Senate. We have been pressing for provisions in the NDAA, in the Coast Guard bill year after year to get our Pentagon and, quite frankly, our Coast Guard to focus more on the Arctic.

As a matter of fact, right now, the NDAA is being marked up. I am going to hustle back over to the Senate side. It is our conference with the House and the Senate. We have my provision, the Arctic Security Initiative in this year's NDAA to make sure that we focus on the Arctic. To your point, Mr. Chairman, the United States has not invested in Arctic infrastructure. The number, actually, of Russian icebreakers is 54, many of which are nuclear-powered. They are weaponized. We have two icebreakers, and one is broken. That is what we have. We are building more. We are looking to purchase off the shelf some. But we need to make sure that we are trying to close this very, very significant icebreaker gap. Even China's icebreaking capacity is on pace to surpass ours in 2025. As you mentioned, Mr. Chairman, they are not even an Arctic nation.

We recognize the importance of freedom of navigation transits through the Taiwan Strait and the South China Sea, but we need to do the same for the Northern Sea route from Europe to the Bering Strait. Putin has called this region the new Suez Canal that he will control. We can't let them do that. So, I commend the Coast

Guard on working to get more icebreakers, commend the Coast Guard cutter *Healy* that transited near the Northern Sea route, near the Russian EEZ for making this difficult and challenging transit.

But icebreakers, Mr. Chairman, are only the beginning. The level of infrastructure, domain awareness, reliable comms that are sufficient to support America's security needs in the Arctic are lacking. As I mentioned, Congress has made important progress. We have begun work on a deepwater port in Nome, Alaska, that is western Alaska, in the Arctic region that can handle icebreakers. It can handle Navy destroyers. But right now, we have no infrastructure anywhere near the Arctic that can even handle Navy ships and American icebreakers.

So, we need infrastructure. We need a whole-of-Government effort. We must respond to bolster our presence, both military and civilian, to make sure that we can protect our National security interests, economic security interests, energy security interests, and environmental security interests that are so critical to our National security.

I do want to mention one final thing. We need to do this in conjunction with all Federal agencies and Arctic communities, especially the very patriotic Alaska Native communities, our Indigenous communities that have been living in the Arctic for literally thousands of years and are some of the most patriotic Americans anywhere.

So, again, Mr. Chairman, this is a critical issue for the 21st Century. It is a key area of great power competition against Russia and China. I really want to commend you and the committee Members to taking the time for this important hearing and just very appreciative.

[The prepared statement of Hon. Sullivan follows:]

STATEMENT OF SENATOR DAN SULLIVAN

NOVEMBER 29, 2023

Thank you Mr. Chairman. I commend the committee's dedication to understanding the complexities of Arctic security and providing me the opportunity to speak about the increasing significance of the Arctic region to our Nation's security.

The Arctic is undergoing monumental changes. Sea ice is receding, opening up an entire ocean that was previously unreachable. This allows access to a wealth of natural resources and makes available maritime trade routes that are thousands of nautical miles shorter than transits using the Suez or Panama Canals. The strategic importance of this region is unquestionable. Arctic security is American security.

Despite that, we as a country are not properly postured to secure our interests in the region.

America is an Arctic nation because of Alaska. My State is at the forefront of Arctic competition and guards the United States against threats from our competitors. We are in a new era of authoritarian aggression. Vladimir Putin and Xi Jinping are both running hostile regimes that seek to control access to the Arctic region. Alaska's proximity to both Russia and China requires that the State play a vital role in securing America's interests in the Arctic and Indo-Pacific. Alaska is the only place on earth with 100 5th generation fighters, long-range discrimination radar, missile defense silos, and other strategic assets that are vital to the defense of our Nation. Because of this, since I came into office in 2015, I have been pressing officials in Washington, DC relentlessly on the need to prioritize our capabilities in the Arctic. We need new and secure infrastructure like icebreakers and deepwater ports; we needed them yesterday.

In recent years, the Russian navy has stepped up the scale of its exercises near Alaska, including in the US Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ). In 2022, a joint Rus-

sian and Chinese naval patrol was sighted near Alaska. That patrol was intercepted and monitored by a Coast Guard cutter to ensure the sovereignty of our territorial waters and the safety of our mariners. In August of this year, a group of 11 Russian and Chinese warships were operating together off the coast of Alaska in the Aleutian Islands. This time, we stepped up our response and sent 4 destroyers from the Lower 48 to intercept this joint Chinese-Russian flotilla. We must take this as a sign of things to come. We not only need more Coast Guard assets, but also a Navy presence back in Alaska. We will need to be able to respond more rapidly in the future. That means places for Navy ships to refuel and refit in the Aleutian Islands and on Alaska's west coast near the Bering Strait.

Unfortunately, the bureaucracy within the Executive branch has been slow to act on the growing threats in the Arctic. Thankfully, through countless hearings and legislative action, Congress has led the charge in growing America's presence in the Arctic. In the fiscal year 2022 NDAA, I authored a provision that required the USNORTHCOM Commander to complete an independent assessment of the resources needed to implement the National Defense Strategy and the service-specific Arctic strategies. This year, I'm working through the NDAA conference process to pass the Arctic Security Initiative, which would require the Defense Department to enhance security in the Arctic region based on the results of that assessment.

The United States has not invested in Arctic infrastructure. Russia has over 50 icebreakers, many of which are nuclear-powered. They have built ports and ice-hardened vessels. Even China's icebreaking capacity is on pace to surpass ours by 2025, despite them having no sovereignty over any Arctic waters.

The United States only has one operational heavy and one medium polar icebreaker. The Coast Guard Cutter *HEALY* recently transited near the Northern Sea Route outside of the Russian EEZ. I applaud the crew of the *HEALY* for making this transit. But we need to be able to do this consistently. We recognize the importance of freedom of navigation transits through the Taiwan Strait and the South China Sea. We need to do the same for the Northern Sea Route from Europe to the Bering Strait.

The Coast Guard is working to get more icebreakers. The Polar Security Cutter acquisition is under way but is not moving fast enough. The program has been continually delayed. This is why I have pushed for the Coast Guard to acquire a commercially-built icebreaker that is available today. Because of a provision in last year's NDAA, the Coast Guard has the authority to procure a commercially-available icebreaker and I am hopeful that we will secure the funding this year.

Icebreakers are only the beginning. The level of infrastructure development, domain awareness, and reliable communications are far from sufficient to support America's security needs in the region.

Congress has made progress. We have begun work on a deepwater port in Nome on Alaska's west coast, which will be critical component for Arctic maritime transportation, and serve as a staging area for search and rescue, pollution response, and security operations. This is a major step forward, but it cannot be the only step. We need a series of secure, strategic ports in the Arctic.

As infrastructure is built out in the Arctic, it will need to be protected from attack, both in the physical and cyber dimensions. Much of the Alaskan Arctic has limited cyber infrastructure, creating single points of failure that leave our systems vulnerable to outages. For example, just this summer a Quintillion fiber optic cable was severed by shifting ice, causing internet and cellphone outages in much of northern and western Alaska. The repair took months.

Arctic security necessitates a whole-of-Government effort. We must bolster our presence, both military and civilian, to effectively respond to emergencies and enforce regulations. We must rely on partnerships between DHS and DOD to keep our Nation safe. We must also work with nongovernmental partners and consult with Arctic communities as we expand our Arctic presence.

The Arctic is a key arena for 21st Century security challenges. I urge the committee to support initiatives that bolster our Arctic capabilities and safeguard our National interests in the region.

Thank you for your time.

Chairman GREEN. Thank you for being here. We deeply appreciate it. I know you have got to rush off to the conference, so—

Mr. SULLIVAN. Got to make sure I get that Arctic security provision in the bill.

Chairman GREEN. Totally get it. Thank you again, sir, for being here. The committee will stand in brief recess while the clerks arrange for the second panel of witnesses.

[Recess.]

Chairman GREEN. I now recognize the Ranking Member, the gentleman from Mississippi, Mr. Thompson, for his opening statement.

Mr. THOMPSON. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. Good morning. I appreciate the committee holding today's hearing on Arctic security and its implication for the homeland. When I served as Chairman, the Homeland Security Committee held multiple hearings and briefings on Arctic security, and I am glad to see the current Majority continuing to conduct oversight on this critical topic. As I have said previously, it is imperative that the committee carry out its oversight responsibilities on the many varied threats facing the homeland.

To be certain, the Arctic is a region of increasing importance to homeland security, and it is one area where I believe there is an opportunity for bipartisan cooperation. Time is of the essence. With climate change, Arctic waters are increasingly open to maritime activity like shipping, energy exploration, fishing, and tourism. Adversaries like Russia and China are trying to gain strategic advantage, and the United States must be ready to assert and protect its interests in the region.

The Coast Guard is central to the United States' efforts and activities in the Arctic, but its capacity is severely limited by a lack of icebreakers. Currently, it has only one heavy polar icebreaker, the *Polar Star*, which was commissioned in 1976 and is well past its expected service life. The vessel is focused on work related to our research station in Antarctica, making it difficult for the Coast Guard to maintain a presence in the Arctic. Meanwhile, Russia has more than 50 icebreakers and has been building more, increasing its military presence in the region by opening new bases, reopening old ones, and enhancing its communications capabilities.

In response to the dire need for more icebreakers and maritime assets built for the Arctic, Congress appropriated historic funding to begin construction of new polar security cutters, or PSCs. The Coast Guard awarded contracts for the first two of these PSCs in 2019, with delivery originally expected late next year. Unfortunately, construction has not yet begun due to a variety of factors, and delivery will be delayed. I hope to hear from the Coast Guard today about the plan going forward and a new time line and cost estimates for the Polar Security Cutters.

This acquisition program will be a long-term effort, so Congress must help ensure shipbuilding stays on budget and meets critical deadlines. In addition to addressing the icebreaker shortage, the United States has to strategize for the long term, since conditions in the Arctic will continue to change and nations like Russia and China will try to leverage those changes to their advantage. Indeed, China has already declared itself a near-Arctic state despite having no geographic connection to the Arctic and will undoubtedly continue to exert its influence in the region.

In recognition of the need for a whole-of-Government strategy, the Biden-Harris administration published a National strategy for the Arctic region just over a year ago, an important step toward ensuring U.S. interests are protected. The strategy includes four pillars, the first of which is security, stating, "We will deter threats to the U.S. homeland and our allies by enhancing the capabilities

to defend our interests in the Arctic and will exercise U.S. Government presence in the Arctic region as required to protect the American people and defend our sovereign territory.” The strategy also rightly focused on addressing climate change and environmental protection. We must follow the science on climate change and plan accordingly for the effects of warming temperatures and reduced sea ice in the region.

Additionally, the strategy highlights the importance of engaging with Indigenous communities in the Arctic. The Coast Guard has established relationships with Alaskan Native communities, and we must broaden and deepen those relationships going forward.

Finally, the strategy recognizes that the United States must engage our international allies and partners on Arctic issues to strengthen our position in the region. Engaging like-minded countries and working together on areas of common interest will be critical going forward. In recognition of the important work to be done, in August 2022, the Biden-Harris administration announced the establishment of an ambassador-at-large for the Arctic region. The ambassador-at-large is charged with advancing U.S. policy in the Arctic, engaging with counterparts in Arctic and non-Arctic nations, as well as Indigenous groups, and working closely with domestic stakeholders. President Biden’s nomination has been pending in the Senate since February 2023.

This fall, the Government Accountability Office reported that the new ambassador-at-large position could help advance U.S. priorities in the Arctic region. I hope this position will be confirmed without further delay.

Today, I look forward to the witnesses sharing their expertise about homeland security priorities in the Arctic and what Congress can do to support them and their priorities. Before I close, I want to express particular appreciation to the Government Accountability Office for their work on Arctic issues and to our witness, Ms. Kenney, for her willingness to testify on extremely short notice just after the Thanksgiving holiday. Mr. Chairman, I ask unanimous consent to enter into the record a statement from Abbie Tingstad of the Rand Corporation.

Chairman GREEN. Without objection, so ordered.
[The information follows:]

STATEMENT OF ABBIE TINGSTAD¹, THE RAND CORPORATION²

NOVEMBER 29, 2023

Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and distinguished Members of the committee, thank you for the opportunity to submit this testimony. As is increas-

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ingly customary when discussing matters related to the Arctic, I begin by acknowledging the diverse Indigenous peoples of the region, including the many Alaska Native groups.

This statement also serves to center my testimony on the idea that Arctic security—in all of its connotations—is fundamentally about people. A rapidly-changing climate is triggering important shifts, generating new risks and opportunities, and bringing forward various weaknesses and strengths. In this testimony, I summarize the series of key transitions under way and revisit the question of whether the United States faces an Arctic security gap and why. I will finish with findings and recommendations based on a recently-published RAND Corporation report,³ mandated by the National Defense Authorization Act for fiscal year 2021,⁴ that pertains to the Arctic capabilities of the U.S. armed forces, which are central to U.S. security in the Arctic and globally. This report examines potential issues related to U.S. access in the Arctic region, particularly in comparison with Russian and Chinese access, and was sponsored by the U.S. Coast Guard (USCG). We find in general that additional investments in capacity for presence in the Arctic region will enhance homeland security in the Far North.

THE ARCTIC REGION FACES SECURITY TRANSITIONS ALONG MANY FRONTS

Outside interest in the Arctic is growing for many reasons. Increasing temperatures, which the Arctic is experiencing at nearly four times the global average, create new concerns related to several types of security. In the past, the Far North was often described as “high north, low tension,” and even appeared to some extent during the Cold War as a notable exception to chilly geopolitical relationships. Yet a warming climate, now with increasingly demonstrable effects, has raised the question of whether a historical ability to cooperate regionally under the auspices of the Arctic Council, among other regional organizations, can be maintained as the Arctic attracts more international attention. And most concerning is the fact that Russia and China are cooperating in the Arctic—that is, at the doorstep of the U.S. homeland.

Furthermore, the migration northward of certain fish and other marine species, as well as the presence of freshwater reserves in the Arctic, make the region increasingly attractive to many countries concerned about food and water security. The Arctic’s well-known undersea oil and natural gas reserves will become easier to extract and bring to global markets over time as thick multi-year sea ice continues to diminish in many areas of the Arctic Ocean. Meanwhile, the current land-based extraction sites will become more difficult to exploit as permafrost melts and ice roads become muddier and unnavigable. Sea routes across the Arctic, once the domain of only the most adventurous, could continue becoming somewhat more accessible for part of the year, particularly along Russia’s coast. Renewable energy—wind, geothermal, hydroelectric, and solar (for part of the year)—can also be generated in the Arctic, which holds reserves of the minerals needed to support new battery and other green energy technologies. The technology and tourism industries are also growing in parts of the Arctic.

Arctic environmental change also creates new challenges for human security, including for local and Indigenous communities. There are concerns about access to traditional and other food sources, contamination of water, respiratory and heat stress problems, and the collapse of coastal communities, as well as seasonal and permanent infrastructure stability, among others. These changes are occurring as permafrost and glaciers melt, sea level rises, summer heat waves and wildfires intensify, and large storms become more frequent.

THREE ISSUES RELATED TO ARCTIC CHANGE ARE OFTEN MISUNDERSTOOD

Recognizing the security issues laid out above is imperative. However, to enhance U.S. security in the Arctic, it is also imperative for U.S. policy makers to be aware of what is not happening in the region. In this vein, I next highlight three factors related to changes under way in the Arctic that are often misunderstood, misrepresented, and/or misinterpreted: (1) How climate change is affecting physical accessi-

³ Abbie Tingstad, Scott Savitz, Benjamin J. Sacks, Yuliya Shokh, Irina A. Chindea, Scott R. Stephenson, Michael T. Wilson, James G. Kallimani, Kristin Van Abel, Stephanie Pezard, Isabelle Winston, Inez Khan, Dan Abel, Clay McKinney, Yvonne K. Crane, Kathryn Giglio, Sherrill Lingel, and Lyle J. Morris, *Report on the Arctic Capabilities of the U.S. Armed Forces*, Homeland Security Operational Analysis Center operated by the RAND Corporation, RR-A1638-1, 2023, https://www.rand.org/pubs/research_reports/RRA1638-1.html.

⁴ Public Law 116-283, William M. (Mac) Thornberry National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 2021, January 1, 2021.

bility, (2) the imminence of conflict for contested resources, and (3) the ability of global geopolitical issues to spill over to regional security matters.

First, regarding physical accessibility, physical changes are not uniformly easing mobility challenges for those living in the Arctic and for people coming in from lower latitudes. In many cases, the opposite is actually true: The rapid diminishment of multi-year sea ice in most areas is increasing the ability of non-icebreaking vessels to operate in the Arctic Ocean during some times of the year. However, this ice loss is uneven across the region; some areas near Russia and Alaska are more accessible than others. Loss of multi-year ice also does not imply safe conditions for transit and other economic activities (e.g., resource extraction, fishing); in fact, the unpredictability of sea ice could make some journeys more hazardous, especially to vessels without the appropriate fortifications and experienced crews. Furthermore, the same drivers of more ocean accessibility are also causing many coastal and inland areas to become less accessible due to permafrost melt, the shortening of ice road seasons, and erosion, among other factors.

Second, no evidence yet exists of a resource race or of impending resource wars. All Arctic land falls clearly under the jurisdiction of one of the eight Arctic states, and there are increasingly fewer land-based territorial disputes. Claims for extended continental shelf rights, which the United States cannot submit due to the fact that it did not ratify the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, follow internationally agreed-on processes. Although the legal status of both the Northwest Passage along the Canadian coast and the Northern Sea Route (NSR) or Northeast Passage along the Russian coast are certainly disputed in a legal sense, the volume of any international shipping through such routes over the coming years is likely to be at a degree much, much smaller than elsewhere in the world—if it exists—leaving the legal status of these routes as important in principle but not practically relevant from an economic standpoint for decades to come. This being said, the NSR will remain critical for the shipping of Russian resources to global markets, especially to Asia, which is a different matter economically (though not legally) than using the route as a shortcut from Europe to Asia and vice versa.

Moving from international to regional focus, there are continuing important discussions about the early integration of rights-holders such as Alaska Native groups into the decision-making process, along with such concepts as shared benefits and risks and free, prior, and informed consent regarding resource-extraction projects. Although the U.S. Government took an important and high-impact step with the Alaska Native Claims Settlement Act,⁵ for example, work on inclusion and securing futures for local communities continues to be important across the Arctic region. The work is not yet done.

Third, with respect to the possibility of global geopolitical issues spilling over to regional security matters, it is true that dialog between Russia, China, the United States, and other Western countries has deteriorated as a result of the war in Ukraine and tensions in the South China Sea and over Taiwan. Yet my experience suggests that these tensions have not directly affected Arctic security, other than the associated difficulties in maintaining dialog across the board. Overall, the Arctic region has remained relatively stable in this uncertain global security environment. Regarding Arctic dialog and cooperation between Russia and the other seven Arctic states, I do not foresee a return to the “business as usual” model that pre-dated the 2022 full-scale invasion of Ukraine. However, among other things, with the restarting of Arctic Council activities and in the context of the day-to-day stewardship of border areas, I observe evidence that there has not been a systemic breakdown in regional security. This makes me cautiously optimistic that Arctic stakeholders can continue to seek opportunities for constructive, collective dialog about the region’s future.

DOES THE UNITED STATES FACE AN ARCTIC SECURITY GAP?

These security transitions, among others, are all good reasons to revisit the question of whether the United States faces an Arctic security gap. Research on Arctic security that my RAND colleagues and I have conducted over recent years suggests that there is no immediate, imminent security threat to the United States stemming from the Arctic. However, we have identified several risks that could ultimately lead to a future gap in security if U.S. access to and presence in the region do not improve to account for some of the key transitions that I have outlined above. The main risks that we identified are as follows:⁶

⁵Public Law 92–203, An Act to Provide for the Settlement of Certain Land Claims of Alaska Natives, and for Other Purposes, December 18, 1971.

⁶See Tingstad et al., 2023.

1. declining populations across much of the Arctic region
 2. limited readiness by the United States to fulfill responsibilities across all plausible contingency scenarios in the Arctic (e.g., for search-and-rescue [SAR] missions)
 3. loss of life, property, economic potential, and environmental integrity due to a lack of readiness
 4. limited U.S. ability to operate with (and rely on) partners
 5. loss of opportunities to counter and diplomatically engage (when tenable) with Russia
 6. possibility of the accidental escalation of tensions between Russia and the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO)
 7. perception of U.S. absence and a security void, inviting more Chinese or another country's presence
 8. possible growth in Chinese influence and ability to conduct covert activities.
- I discuss these risks in detail below.

I first raise the key issue of declining populations across much of the Arctic, including in Alaska. Generally speaking, Arctic citizens have been moving in recent decades from smaller northern villages to larger towns and cities in the region, or out of the region altogether. There are many factors that are driving this shift in demographics, including the limited or lack of access to education and livelihoods and to basic services, such as utilities and transportation. It is difficult to imagine preserving the security of the U.S. Arctic without a robust contingent of local partners that often serves as the eyes and ears of the broader U.S. Government and as first responders in many instances. It is equally difficult to accept the often-degraded access to basic necessities that local Alaskan and many Arctic communities face, which do and could inhibit outside homeland security representatives from conducting their presence and response roles in the region as well.

The second risk is related to the United States' limited ability to fulfill responsibilities in the Arctic. Due to limited and primarily seasonal presence in Arctic areas of Alaska, the USCG and other U.S. Federal entities lack the typical infrastructure, capabilities, and capacity found in other areas of the United States that permit the regular and extensive execution of such missions as search and rescue, law enforcement, environmental response, and disaster response. From an international perspective, the United States and other Arctic countries have signed key agreements, including the Agreement on Cooperation on Aeronautical and Maritime Search and Rescue in the Arctic (2011),⁷ the Agreement on Cooperation on Marine Oil Pollution Preparedness and Response in the Arctic (2013),⁸ and the Agreement on Enhancing International Arctic Scientific Cooperation (2017).⁹ Yet it is not clear whether the United States and the other Arctic signatory countries have the capabilities and capacities to fulfill the responsibilities and needs that are outlined in these agreements under varying scenarios. However, many of the other Arctic countries, including Russia, yield more-extensive Arctic-based and—focused capabilities, such as in icebreaking and transportation logistics, for response compared with the United States.

From a U.S. perspective, this disparity in capabilities is an important risk to heed because there is a substantial difference between conducting SAR missions immediately off the coast of a location such as the North Slope Borough in Alaska, where local responders may be able to quickly carry out an active response, and in an area such as eastern Greenland, where the *Ocean Explorer* ran aground in September 2023. During this incident—in which there were fortunately no casualties—it took multiple days for a vessel navigating relatively nearby to pull the cruise ship free.

Additional consideration must also be given to the ability of the United States and other Arctic countries to enforce existing agreements. A recent milestone in Arctic governance was the development of the International Code for Ships Operating in Polar Waters (Polar Code),¹⁰ through the auspices of the International Maritime Organization (IMO) and which entered into force in 2017. This code lays out important guidelines and needs for ships operating in specified areas at high northern and southern latitudes. Still, in September 2023, Russia permitted oil tankers without the required hull engineering to transit the NSR for the first time. It has not been

⁷ Agreement on Cooperation on Aeronautical and Maritime Search and Rescue in the Arctic, signed at Nuuk, Greenland, May 12, 2011.

⁸ Agreement on Cooperation on Marine Oil Pollution Preparedness and Response in the Arctic, signed at Kiruna, Sweden, May 15, 2013.

⁹ Agreement on Enhancing International Arctic Scientific Cooperation, signed at Fairbanks, Alaska, May 11, 2017.

¹⁰ See International Maritime Organization, "International Code for Ships Operating in Polar Waters (Polar Code)," webpage, undated, <https://www.imo.org/en/ourwork/safety/pages/polar-code.aspx>.

immediately clear what, if anything, can be done about such code violations in the near term.

A third risk is that the lack of the United States' and other Arctic states' ability to respond to various possible contingencies in the Arctic can result in loss of life, property, economic potential, and environmental integrity. These tragedies can occur anywhere in the world, but the Arctic is one region where U.S. readiness to prevent, mitigate, and respond to life-threatening incidents and other types of threats is very low due to a combination of limited U.S. capacity and capabilities in areas relevant to Arctic emergencies, vast distances, and a harsh environment.

Historically low levels of human activity and presence in the region have limited the occurrence of such consequences. Yet, there is much concern surrounding the potential for increased risks to human life (e.g., through increasing cruise ship traffic, slow response to storm damage), the environment (e.g., via fuel spills), and infrastructure (e.g., through storm damage). For instance, in 2022, Typhoon Merbok severely destroyed infrastructure and had impacts on many displaced families and livelihoods in western coastal Alaska, serving as a sobering reminder of the power that one storm can have.

The fourth risk focuses on partnering as a way of reducing a country's risk, especially in a region such as the Arctic where all Arctic states have fairly limited infrastructure and capabilities. However, without having adequate access and presence, as well as sufficient capabilities, to bring to the table, the United States will be able to participate only in a limited fashion in exercises relevant to contingency preparedness, readiness, and response. The United States has tremendous capabilities across air, ground, maritime, space, and other areas, some of which are located in Alaska or in other U.S. States, such as Washington, Maine, and New York, which are geographically proximal to the Arctic. The vast majority of these assets, though not all, are primarily dedicated to such strategic needs as deterrence and global power projection.

The United States must also be able to offer more Arctic-specific or at least Arctic-relevant capabilities in order to best position itself to take advantage of what other Arctic partners have to offer. For example, any theoretical plans to formally network fuel and connect logistics points across North American high northern latitudes to enable contingency response would necessitate the inclusion of locations in Alaska and perhaps Maine and New York to provide the best value domestically and for potential partners, such as Canada, Greenland, and Denmark.

The fifth risk concerns the impact that Russia's full-scale war on Ukraine has on preventing the United States and its like-minded allies and partners in the region from engaging in Arctic "business as usual." The reality is that the United States shares a maritime border with Russia, and Russia will continue to be an important player in the Far North for years to come as the region's largest country with great economic aspirations for the Arctic and a substantial military presence there. Thus, managing an Arctic relationship with Russia is a necessity and requires that the United States improve its access to and presence in the Arctic to successfully do so. This will facilitate engagement when needed to conduct responsibilities and improve the United States' ability to balance Russia's presence around strategic areas, such as the Bering Strait. More regional activity runs the risk of escalating tensions or causing accidents, which further emphasizes the importance of a U.S. presence that can facilitate domain awareness and strong communications.

The sixth risk concerns the potential for accidental escalation of NATO-Russia tensions. The United States' limited access to and presence in the Arctic can also prevent the U.S. Government from having the appropriate domain awareness, communications, and other capabilities necessary to prevent military accidents and escalation. This escalatory potential is particularly relevant in the context of Sweden's imminent accession to NATO, which would mean that 7 of 8 Arctic countries will be NATO members. In this context, Russia may increasingly perceive NATO encroachment in the Arctic, which could potentially result in further increasing tensions in the region.

The last two risks that we identified relate to China's presence in the Arctic. China is not an Arctic state, although it has been involved in regional scientific research and relevant intergovernmental organizations for years, among a group of other countries, such as the United Kingdom, Germany, Japan, and South Korea. China has participated in the existing Arctic governance structures as an observer within the Arctic Council, a participant in Polar Code development through the IMO, and a signatory of the International Agreement to Prevent Unregulated Fishing in the High Seas of the Central Arctic Ocean,¹¹ for example. At the same time,

¹¹International Agreement to Prevent Unregulated Fishing in the High Seas of the Central Arctic Ocean, signed at Reykjavik, Iceland, May 20, 2021.

China has been particularly vocal among non-Arctic states about its presence in the region and in regional decision making—famously calling itself a “near-Arctic state.”¹² Its willingness to partner with Russia post-full-scale invasion of Ukraine and its status as a U.S. competitor are also cause for watchfulness.

One concern for Arctic state sovereignty is the possibility that China (or another non-Arctic state) would potentially step in to fill a real or potential regional security void, challenging sovereignty or, even more likely, justifying an incremental increase of its own presence. A plausible scenario under which this could occur is if a Chinese maritime vessel were challenged (wrongfully, according to Beijing) on illicit or hybrid activity, or if a SAR response to such a vessel under distress were viewed as ineffective. These situations could, in theory, garner a response that Arctic states are overreaching or conducting ineffective operations, respectively, potentially opening the door for Beijing to justify China’s stronger presence to protect its assets and interests. The recently-signed maritime law enforcement agreement between Moscow and Beijing,¹³ though not Arctic-specific, was signed in Murmansk, Russia’s largest Arctic city and adjacent to its Northern Fleet headquarters. This agreement could be an early type of indicator that China sees a need for an expanded role for itself in the region.

Another type of risk is that through increasing access and presence, China might be able to leverage locations, technologies, and other means to secure information and other advantages. Despite the lack of firm evidence of this to date, this risk may be particularly acute in the Arctic, given the difficulties in surveilling many regional activities across vast distances and with a severe lack of infrastructure to do so. Furthermore, these same challenges might provide the conditions under which covert activities can be pursued. U.S. presence in the region could certainly help maintain awareness and provide courses of action to counter questionable activities if necessary.

IMPROVING U.S. ARCTIC ACCESS AND PRESENCE WILL ENHANCE THE SECURITY OF THE UNITED STATES

The *Report on the Arctic Capabilities of the U.S. Armed Forces* contains several findings and recommendations for improving U.S. presence in and access to the Arctic region to maintain security and avoid the risks detailed above. The report’s five key findings are as follows:¹⁴

First, the USCG, even when working with joint partners, lacks the capacity to meet the Nation’s strategic aims in the Arctic. Although the United States has substantial strategic capabilities for operating from or through the Arctic, its capacity and capability for conducting operations to secure its Arctic interests are more limited than those of other Arctic countries, based on scale. This includes key needs in access (surface maritime, land, and air at tactical and operational—rather than strategic—scales), domain awareness (e.g., sensors), communications (satellites, fiber-optic cables, etc.), and logistics (transportation and energy). Generally speaking, other Arctic countries have scaled their capabilities and capacity proportionally to their respective Arctic needs and to reflect the natural hazards and military threats they are facing, as well as the sizes of their populations and economies. Similarly, China’s polar investments mirror its scientific and economic ambitions and lack of Arctic territory.

Second, the U.S. armed services will be challenged in the Arctic by foreign military and commercial activities. The Arctic has become increasingly visible globally through climate change and expectations of regional economic potential, which may also make the region more vulnerable to the spillover of geopolitical tensions or even armed conflict. U.S. armed forces will likely increasingly contend with strategic competition in this region to promote U.S. interests and support allies and partners. However, we did not assess that the Arctic would see an independent conflict caused by tensions arising over regional economic or other issues.

In addition, U.S. armed forces—especially the USCG, because of its particular statutory missions that include law-enforcement roles—will need to monitor the growth in regional commercial activities, both licit and illicit. The most pressing area will be in continuing to monitor and manage fisheries, especially anticipated growth in illegal, unreported, and unregulated fishing as global demand for protein increases, fisheries respond to a warming climate, and Indigenous groups in some areas gain more political and economic autonomy. Growth in tourism, especially

¹² People’s Republic of China, State Council, *China’s Arctic Policy*, January 26, 2018.

¹³ “China, Russia Sign Memorandum of Understanding on Maritime Law Enforcement,” ed. by Himani Sarkar, Reuters, April 26, 2023.

¹⁴ Tingstad et al., 2023.

ecotourism, will increase demand for SAR and environmental response, as well as for customs and border protection.

Third, potential security risks to USCG forces are largely driven by U.S. capacity and capability issues. Limitations on U.S. capacity and capability to scale up for enduring regional presence contribute to three types of issues:

- First, there are scenarios in which the USCG, more generally, would find it difficult to perform self-protection and self-rescue regardless of the reason (e.g., military threat, law enforcement problem, natural hazard) for the need.
- Second, these limitations set the conditions for developing a security void in parts of the North American Arctic. Limited domain awareness, the inability to quickly communicate relevant information, and a lack of presence to proactively manage problems place USCG forces at a starting disadvantage before a bad actor ever makes a move.
- Third, these same challenges affect the ability of the USCG and other U.S. armed forces to respond to emerging situations (including NATO defense) elsewhere in the Far North.

The United States has been fortunate that the overall security risks in the Arctic region have historically been limited. In the future, these risks will be likely to remain less severe than those in other parts of the United States and the world in which the USCG and other armed forces operate. In other words, the so-called pacing threat in the Arctic is not an external set of bad actors like it is elsewhere. The United States itself is placing the USCG and its armed forces in a difficult position in the Arctic by necessitating presence through overarching strategies and plans without providing the appropriate capabilities in sufficient capacities to perform these missions to the same level of success as they would be if performed elsewhere in the United States and in the world.

Fourth, U.S. presence cannot be scaled up without trained personnel, domain awareness, communications, and logistics. For many, the concept of armed forces' presence denotes physical and technological capabilities: ships, submarines, aircraft, ground vehicles, and similar platforms. There is no doubt that investment in such platforms would greatly promote U.S. Arctic access and presence. Yet, our study emphasized four other types of essential capabilities without which next-generation or recapitalized platforms would not be effective or even operational: trained personnel, domain awareness, communications, and logistics. Personnel need to be acclimated to operating in the extreme Arctic environment, where even basic operational tasks can be difficult. Domain awareness remains limited owing to the use of a single Arctic-dedicated icebreaker (USCGC *Healy*), few overflights, and relatively few early warning stations. Polar conditions and poor infrastructure hamper communications, while logistics suffer from few roads and viable airstrips.

Fifth, the Arctic physical environment will continue to be a formidable adversary. Protecting the armed forces during their missions to secure the United States' interests in the Arctic region is of utmost importance. Although there are various military threats, such as anti-ship and anti-aircraft missiles, our research suggests that the likeliest and most-consequential threats will come from the Arctic's physical environment and the present lack of capability, capacity, and preparedness for dealing with these challenges. The dangers of navigating through vast, poorly-charted areas with extreme weather conditions; operating in a data vacuum with limited communications; and lacking personnel trained and ready to persist in a harsh, logistics-poor environment are—and will continue to be—formidable.

In response to the five findings presented above, our recommendations are as follows:¹⁵

- Bolster momentum in implementing national, U.S. Department of Homeland Security, USCG, U.S. Department of Defense, and military service Arctic strategies. Funding and the need to attend to other priorities can make it challenging to bridge the gap between Arctic strategies and action. It is merely a fact that, if the Arctic is not clearly promoted in priority-setting national strategies, it will continue to be difficult to invest in the capabilities, people, partnerships, and training and exercises that Arctic strategies suggest are needed for securing National interests in the region.
- Continue efforts to expand funding for priority USCG and U.S. Department of Homeland Security needs. While there are no silver bullets and no single investment will resolve the multitude of problems, some initial priorities include continuing funding for new icebreakers and the deepwater port at Nome, Alaska, and making investments in “low-hanging fruit” for domain awareness and communications.

¹⁵Tingstad et al., 2023.

- Seek opportunities to benefit from commercial investments, including efforts to engage in research and development with commercial partners. We recommend considering expanding support for selected fiber communications, maritime and aviation logistics (including for mobile infrastructure), and autonomous-vehicle projects if viable and useful.
- Strengthen research partnerships, including those across the interagency and with local, Tribal, and university partners.
- Strengthen international partnerships, expanding them when possible, including intelligence- and other information-sharing more widely and sooner when possible.

To conclude, security requires continuous effort to maintain, particularly in periods of transition along the many dimensions that the Arctic is experiencing—from climate change to demographic shifts to economic opportunities and risks to geopolitical dynamics. As an Arctic nation, it is the United States’ responsibility to take steps toward enhancing regional security. The recently-released Implementation Plan for the United States’ National Strategy for the Arctic Region and the USCG’s Arctic Strategic Outlook Implementation Plan,¹⁶ and the funding provided for the first new icebreakers, for example, are important initial steps. The United States must now continue this momentum.

I thank the committee for the opportunity to submit this testimony and look forward to addressing any questions.

Mr. THOMPSON. Mr. Chairman. I yield back.
[The statement of Ranking Member Thompson follows:]

STATEMENT OF RANKING MEMBER BENNIE G. THOMPSON

NOVEMBER 29, 2023

I appreciate the committee holding today’s hearing on Arctic security and its implications for the homeland. When I served as Chairman, the Homeland Security Committee held multiple hearings and briefings on Arctic security, and I am glad to see the current Majority continuing to conduct oversight on this critical topic.

As I have said previously, it is imperative that the committee carry out its oversight responsibilities on the many, varied threats facing the homeland. To be certain, the Arctic is a region of increasing importance to homeland security, and it is one area where I believe there is opportunity for bipartisan cooperation. Time is of the essence. With climate change, Arctic waters are increasingly open to maritime activity like shipping, energy exploration, fishing, and tourism. Adversaries like Russia and China are trying to gain strategic advantage, and the United States must be ready to assert and protect its interests in the region.

The Coast Guard is central to the United States’ efforts and activities in the Arctic, but its capacity is severely limited by a lack of icebreakers. Currently, it has only one heavy polar icebreaker, the *Polar Star*, which was commissioned in 1976 and is well past its expected service life. The vessel is focused on work related to our research station in Antarctica, making it difficult for the Coast Guard to maintain a presence in the Arctic. Meanwhile, Russia has more than 50 icebreakers and has been building more, increasing its military presence in the region by opening new bases, reopening old ones, and enhancing its communications capabilities.

In response to the dire need for more icebreakers and maritime assets built for the Arctic, Congress appropriated historic funding to begin construction of new Polar Security Cutters or “PSCs.” The Coast Guard awarded contracts for the first two of these PSCs in 2019, with delivery originally expected late next year. Unfortunately, construction has not yet begun due to a variety of factors and delivery will be delayed. I hope to hear from the Coast Guard today about the plan going forward and the new time line and cost estimate for the Polar Security Cutters. This acquisition program will be a long-term effort, so Congress must help ensure shipbuilding stays on budget and meets critical deadlines.

In addition to addressing the icebreaker shortage, the United States has to strategize for the long term, since conditions in the Arctic will continue to change and nations like Russia and China will try to leverage those changes to their advantage. Indeed, China has already declared itself a “Near-Arctic state”—despite having no geographic connection to the Arctic—and will undoubtedly continue to try to continue to exert its influence in the region.

¹⁶ White House, “Fact Sheet: Implementation Plan for the United States’ National Strategy for the Arctic Region,” Briefing Room, October 23, 2023; U.S. Coast Guard, Arctic Strategic Outlook Implementation Plan, October 2023.

In recognition of the need for a whole-of-Government strategy, the Biden-Harris administration published the National Strategy for the Arctic Region just over a year ago—an important step toward ensuring U.S. interests are protected. The Strategy includes four pillars, the first of which is security, stating “we will deter threats to the U.S. homeland and our allies by enhancing the capabilities to defend our interests in the Arctic . . .” and “will exercise U.S. Government presence in the Arctic region as required to protect the American people and defend our sovereign territory”.

The Strategy also rightly focuses on addressing climate change and environmental protection. We must follow the science on climate change and plan accordingly for the effects of warming temperatures and reduced sea ice in the region.

Additionally, the Strategy highlights the importance of engaging with indigenous communities in the Arctic. The Coast Guard has established relationships with Alaska Native communities, and we must broaden and deepen those relationships going forward.

Finally, the Strategy recognizes that the United States must engage our international allies and partners on Arctic issues to strengthen our position in the region. Engaging like-minded countries and working together on areas of common interest will be critical going forward.

In recognition of the important work to be done, in August 2022 the Biden-Harris administration announced the establishment of an ambassador-at-large for the Arctic Region. The ambassador-at-large is charged with advancing U.S. policy in the Arctic, engaging with counterparts in Arctic and non-Arctic nations as well as Indigenous groups, and working closely with domestic stakeholders. President Biden’s nomination has been pending in the Senate since February 2023. This fall, the Government Accountability Office reported that the new ambassador-at-large position could help advance U.S. priorities in the Arctic region. I hope this position will be confirmed without further delay.

Today, I look forward to the witnesses sharing their expertise about homeland security priorities in the Arctic and what Congress can do to support those priorities and your efforts to protect them.

Before I close, I want to express particular appreciation to the Government Accountability Office for their work on Arctic issues and to our witness, Ms. Kenney, for her willingness to testify on extremely short notice just after the Thanksgiving holiday.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I want to thank the Ranking Member for his opening comments. I am pleased to welcome our second panel of witnesses. I ask the witnesses to please stand and raise your right hand.

[Witnesses sworn.]

Chairman GREEN. Let the record reflect that the witnesses have answered in the affirmative. Thank you, and you may be seated.

I would like to now formally introduce our witnesses. Vice Admiral Peter Gautier. Did I pronounce that correctly, sir?

Mr. GAUTIER. It’s Gautier, sir, unless you’re in Mississippi, and that’s Gautier.

Chairman GREEN. OK. Well, I am from Mississippi, so, that works. Assumed the duties of Coast Guard deputy commandant for operations in June 2022. In this capacity, he is responsible for the development of operational strategy, policy, guidance, and resources that address National priorities. Ms. Christa Brzozowski serves as the acting assistant secretary of trade and economic security at the U.S. Department of Homeland Security. In this capacity, Ms. Brzozowski oversees a team focused on a wide range of National trade and economic security policy issues. Thank you. Ms. Chelsa Kenney serves as the director for the International Affairs and Trade Team for the U.S. Government Accountability Office. I thank the witnesses for being here today, and I now recognize Vice Admiral Gautier for 5 minutes to summarize his opening statement.

**STATEMENT OF VICE ADMIRAL PETER GAUTIER, DEPUTY
COMMANDANT FOR OPERATIONS, U.S. COAST GUARD**

Mr. GAUTIER. Thank you very much. Good morning, Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and the distinguished Members of the committee. The Coast Guard is deeply appreciative for your interest in the Arctic and the crucial role that the Coast Guard plays in promoting peace, stability, and prosperity, and cooperation across the Arctic region through our operations, engagements, partnerships, and influence. I ask that my written testimony be entered into the record.

So, Chairman Green, Ranking Member, your statements, in addition to Senator Sullivan's statements, very eloquently summarize the types of threats that we're facing in the Arctic at large and the Coast Guard's critical role in the Arctic region. I'd just like to maybe reinforce some of the key points that you had made.

We are witnessing a dramatic transformation in the Arctic's physical, operational, and geostrategic environment. We're witnessing first-hand the increasing impacts of climate change and how it's opening up new access to Arctic waters. This drives greater activity in the Arctic region and with it, increased risk across the maritime sector. The Coast Guard is deeply concerned about the rising strategic risk to our Nation as Russia and China compete for diplomatic, economic, and strategic advantage, and influence in the Arctic.

While the mission of the high latitudes have evolved since the Coast Guard started operating there 150 years ago, our commitment to the region has remained constant. We're operating forward to address the safety and security of our Arctic residents and mariners who make their living there homeporting new cutters, investing in infrastructure and capabilities, prioritizing our operations in the region, and strengthening our international partnerships. Changing conditions in the Arctic are driving increased demand for Coast Guard services, and we have a sense of urgency to make sure we can deliver those services now and well into the future.

Despite the geographical remoteness and logistical challenges inherent in all operations in the Arctic, the Coast Guard is meeting demands through our flexible and expeditionary approach. This year in Operation Arctic Shield, we increased seasonal presence in the U.S. Arctic by deploying cutters, aircraft, and shore forces to respond to search-and-rescue cases, inspect bulk oil facilities, complete commercial fishing vessel exams, conduct oil spill and mass rescue exercises, and training and outreach events across 91 Arctic communities.

Coast Guard cutters provide persistent presence along the U.S.-Russia maritime boundary line. Each summer now, as you've heard, the Coast Guard cutters intercept Russian and Chinese military vessels sailing through the U.S. exclusive economic zone. Both nations have declared the Arctic a strategic priority, and they continue to make significant investments to advance their own interests.

We, the Coast Guard, need to make significant investments too. The Coast Guard appreciates the continued support from Congress to build the next generation of Coast Guard capability for the Arctic. A top acquisition priority is the Polar Security cutter, and we're

working with Bollinger, Mississippi shipyard to advance that effort. We've asked for the funding in this year's budget request to increase near-term presence in the Arctic through acquisition of a commercially-available medium polar icebreaker. With Congress's help, we're moving forward to build the shoreside infrastructure necessary to support a fleet to enable it to operate in the harshest conditions on Earth to advance our U.S. interests.

The Coast Guard strategic influence extends well beyond just the U.S. Arctic to the region at large. Through the Arctic Council and the Arctic Coast Guard Forum, we continue to work with like-minded nations to advance shared interests. This year, we exercised with partners off Greenland and the Beaufort Sea to expand search-and-rescue and pollution response interoperability across the international community. The Coast Guard's polar icebreaker *Healy*, working with the scientific community, service polar research buoys just north of Russia's exclusive economic zone, and continued sailing to Europe for engagements with Norway, Denmark, and Iceland, as just a few examples.

Never has the Coast Guard leadership been more important in the Arctic than it is right now. As captured in a host of national security and Arctic-related strategies, the Coast Guard is in a unique position within Government to confront historic maritime challenges and keep the Arctic peaceful, stable, prosperous, and cooperative. The Coast Guard is committed to assert all efforts to meet these challenges. Thank you again, Chairman and Ranking Member, for this opportunity. I look forward to your questions.

[The prepared statement of Admiral Gautier follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF VICE ADMIRAL PETER GAUTIER

29 NOVEMBER 2023

INTRODUCTION

Good morning, Chair Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and distinguished Members of the committee. It is my pleasure to be here today to discuss the U.S. Coast Guard's role in advancing our U.S. National interests across the Arctic. The United States is 1 of only 8 Arctic states with both sovereign rights and sovereign responsibilities to safeguard our respective interests. In a region where presence means not only influence, but also security, the U.S. Coast Guard has been a key leader and interagency partner in shaping the Arctic security environment for over 150 years.

The Arctic is undergoing a dramatic transformation of its physical, operational, and geostrategic environment. We're witnessing first-hand the increasing impacts of climate change and how it is opening up new access to Arctic waters. Arctic activity is increasing and evolving at a rapid pace, from a surge in oil and gas exploration a decade ago to growth in types and locations of vessel transits, including an expansion of environmental tourism. The dynamic and accelerated changes in the Arctic environment make Arctic waters more accessible, creating new opportunities and challenges.

At the same time, the Arctic is a region of increasing strategic competition with the potential for elevating geopolitical tensions. In the U.S. Arctic, the U.S. Coast Guard is engaging more often with a growing number of strategic partners and competitors. Among the competitors, the Service is observing an increased presence by the People's Republic of China (PRC) and Russia, involved in both individual and combined military activities.

A significant level of investment is needed to advance our Nation's interests in the Arctic, and I embrace the trust Congress and the American people have placed in the U.S. Coast Guard. The Service will continue to prioritize actions that safeguard U.S. interests while promoting safe, secure, and environmentally responsible maritime activity in the Arctic.

NATIONAL SECURITY PRIORITIES ACROSS THE ARCTIC

In 2022, the administration released updates to both the National Security Strategy (NSS) and the National Strategy for the Arctic Region (NSAR). The NSS emphasizes constraining Russia and out-competing the PRC. The 2022 NSAR establishes priorities within the Arctic, addressing the climate crisis with greater urgency, expanding scientific research, recognizing the need to advance U.S. leadership at home and abroad, and directing new capability investments. The NSAR emphasizes both National defense and homeland security, and states our highest priority is to protect the American people and our sovereign territory and rights. The administration recently released the Implementation Plan for the NSAR that serves as a blueprint for the Nation's approach to implementing actions within these national strategies. These documents provide clear strategic direction and messaging both domestically and to international allies, partners, and competitors alike, and the U.S. Coast Guard is important to their success.

The U.S. Coast Guard contributed to developing both the NSS and NSAR, and continues to be at the forefront of Arctic strategic leadership. We published the U.S. Coast Guard's Arctic Strategic Outlook Implementation Plan last month. The Implementation Plan underscores the U.S. Coast Guard's commitment to promoting safety, sovereignty, and stewardship in the region, describing actions the Service will take over the next decade, including continuing our efforts to increase Arctic communications capabilities, expanding Arctic surface capabilities, strengthening the Arctic Coast Guard Forum (ACGF) and Arctic Council, and modernizing the U.S. Arctic Marine Transportation System (MTS). The Implementation Plan was developed by the U.S. Coast Guard's newly-established Polar Coordination Office, which serves as the linkage between U.S. Coast Guard Headquarters, Area Commands, and external partners to efficiently and effectively coordinate polar policy, planning, and resourcing Arctic strategies and operations. These collective actions, together with broader diplomatic, economic, and strategic engagement activities, are crucial for U.S. Arctic security.

STRATEGY TO ACTION

A peaceful, stable, prosperous Arctic region that is increasingly open to human activity requires responsible behavior in accordance with international norms and strong governance. In the maritime domain, the United States needs to be present, collaborate with others, and model professional behavior at sea. With our unique combination of authorities as an armed force, a law enforcement agency, a regulatory agency, and a humanitarian service, the U.S. Coast Guard is an ideal instrument for the Nation to responsibly govern the U.S. Arctic maritime environment. The U.S. Coast Guard continues to excel in all of these elements, to include setting an example of responsible governance and reinforcing the rule of law through operational presence and strategic leadership.

The U.S. Coast Guard acts at all regional scales to support U.S. strategic objectives, and to assert international leadership to advance cooperation and uphold international law, rules, norms, and standards for Arctic coastal states and other non-Arctic flag states whose ships sail in Arctic waters. The U.S. Coast Guard consistently provides guidance and direction through preeminent multilateral forums such as the Arctic Council and the International Maritime Organization (IMO). The 2022 NSAR emphasizes the importance of both institutions, as well as the ACGF, to enhancing national security for the United States and our like-minded allies and partners.

The ACGF acts as a bridge between diplomacy and operations by serving as an independent, complementary body to the Arctic Council, with an operational focus on safe and environmentally-responsible Arctic maritime activity. Since 2017, the U.S. Coast Guard has conducted exercises with partner Arctic states through the ACGF and the Arctic Council to enhance interoperability and provide a platform for direct dialog among Arctic agencies fulfilling Coast Guard-like functions.

In 2021, the Arctic Council and the ACGF issued a joint statement of cooperation to enhance collaboration on both search-and-rescue and oil spill preparedness and response. Since then, the U.S. Coast Guard has assumed the chair of the Combined Operations Working Group (COWG) under Norway's chairmanship of the ACGF. In October, the ACGF re-established live, in-person meetings to address critical issues and to commence planning of a 2024 tabletop exercise (TTX) and 2025 live exercise (LIVEX). These meetings were key in sustaining alignment between critical partners. In COWG sessions, participants discussed critical issues facing all states, with emphasis on increases in the number and size of cruise ships anticipated to visit the Arctic in the immediate future, as well as respective capabilities for responding to environmental disasters in the region. These discussions serve as a foundation

for developing exercises to re-enforce critical partnerships and ultimately achieve the coordination and interoperability necessary to successfully respond to incidents in the region.

SECURITY, PRESENCE, AND PREPAREDNESS

The geopolitical environment in the Arctic continues to evolve as state and non-state actors seek to advance their interests in the region. Allies, partners, and competitors increasingly contend for diplomatic, economic, and strategic advantage and influence. Russia and the PRC exemplify this competition. Both have declared the Arctic a strategic priority; both have made significant investments in new or refurbished capabilities; and both are attempting to exert direct or indirect influence across the region using all of their instruments of national power.

The U.S. Coast Guard is directly observing increased strategic competition in the U.S. Arctic. Through the operations of the U.S. Coast Guard Pacific Area Command and its Seventeenth District (D17), which is responsible for U.S. Coast Guard activities for an over 3,853,500-square-mile area including Alaska and the Arctic, the U.S. Coast Guard meets presence with presence, through Operation Frontier Sentinel, both to counter competition and positively influence behavior. Over the past 2 years, the U.S. Coast Guard has provided operational presence and monitored a Chinese military Surface Action Group, as well as a combined Russian-Chinese Task Group, operated in the U.S. Exclusive Economic Zone. The U.S. Coast Guard also redirected a National Security Cutter to ensure the safety of U.S. fishing vessels in the U.S. Exclusive Economic Zone while Russian ships conducted missile exercises. In these instances, the U.S. Coast Guard's visible forward presence ensured that Russia and China operated in accordance with international law.

In the Atlantic segment of the Arctic, the U.S. Coast Guard's Atlantic Area Command actively participates in opportunities to reinforce the Service's role as a trusted, reliable partner in the region, including engagements with U.S. Navy, Canadian, Danish, French, and other allies. In June 2023, the U.S. Coast Guard participated in Exercise ARGUS 2023, the sixth exercise in a series of annual non-military exercises in the Arctic.

The exercise included ships and aircraft from Denmark, Greenland, France, and the U.S. Coast Guard. Also in June 2023, the U.S. Coast Guard, the Danish Joint Arctic Command, the French Atlantic Command, and local Greenlandic authorities executed a Combined Joint Disaster Relief and Search and Rescue (SAR) exercise. The exercise spanned 5 days, and included force integration training, navigation exercises, towing exercises, damage control exercises, SAR searches, air drops, and hoist exercises. In August 2023, U.S. Coast Guard participated in Operation NANOOK along with Denmark, France, and Canada. This exercise deployed forces in a Combined Task Group to demonstrate capabilities and integration with multinational defense allies and exchanged best practices during fleet integration training. Collectively, these exercises improved our capacity to respond to maritime threats and advanced the U.S. Coast Guard and broader U.S. Government's standing and influence with key Arctic partners.

The U.S. Coast Guard will continue to exhibit model governance grounded in international law, rules, norms, and standards, including freedom of navigation in the U.S. Arctic and to empower like-minded partners and allies to do the same in their Arctic waters. This year, U.S. Coast Guard Cutter *Healy* completed an around-the-world voyage from the high Arctic above Asia and Europe to the U.S. East Coast before returning to its homeport. While under way, operations supported a blend of national priorities across the Arctic, including supporting scientific activities in partnership with the National Science Foundation (NSF) along the edge of the Russian Exclusive Economic Zone. *Healy* exercised U.S. presence in the Chukchi, East Siberian, and Laptev Seas, in accordance with international law, and experienced numerous professional encounters with Russian vessels and aircraft.

Healy then continued transiting east to conduct at-sea engagements and port calls in Norway, Denmark, and Iceland. These engagements reinforced both the U.S. Coast Guard and the Nation's enduring commitment to deepening our cooperation with the international community, promoting access in accordance with international law, and supporting scientific research on the impacts of climate change to better enable operational and strategic decisions.

Consistent with the whole-of-Government approach highlighted in the NSAR, the U.S. Coast Guard has long provided Arctic access by including interagency and international scientists aboard *Healy* to conduct critical scientific research as *Healy* operates throughout the region. Robust partnerships with institutions like the NSF, U.S. Arctic Research Commission, the Woodrow Wilson Polar Institute, National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), U.S. Navy, and U.S. National Ice

Center enables the U.S. Coast Guard, along with our National and international partners, to access remote Arctic Ocean locations, conduct hydrographic surveys, implement elements of the Central Arctic Ocean Fisheries Agreement, protect the maritime environment, build community resilience, and shape international security norms. Research also informs decision making to reduce potential operational and strategic consequences.

Since 2009, the U.S. Coast Guard has influenced Arctic governance and sustainable development through Operation Arctic Shield. This operation demonstrates the U.S. Coast Guard's operational capability, asserts leadership, and models responsible international governance in a region of key geostrategic importance. Operation Arctic Shield delivers a full suite of U.S. Coast Guard services to residents and waterway users across Alaska and the U.S. Arctic region.

This work strengthens the MTS, protects the environment, and supports the resilience of remote communities. This year, U.S. Coast Guard personnel conducted extensive marine safety-oriented regulatory activities in 91 villages, inspecting bulk oil facilities and commercial vessels, and issuing commercial fishing safety decals. Each village deployment saw U.S. Coast Guard members integrating with the local communities and governments to enhance relationships, build partnerships, and provide training in areas such as boating safety and ice rescue. U.S. Coast Guard presence in the region is by far the largest of any Federal agency. The U.S. Coast Guard is also well aware of serious challenges facing many communities in Western Alaska stemming from the declines of certain fisheries in the Bering Sea. Through mechanisms such as the Task Force on the Northern Bering Sea Climate Resilience Area, the Coast Guard is participating with a broad range of Federal departments and agencies in an effort to address these challenges, in partnership with representatives of affected communities.

Preparing for complex contingencies in the U.S. Arctic is a National priority. This year, D17 completed a Bering Strait pollution response exercise to advance the region's preparations for a large transboundary oil spill. The exercise included a full-scale exercise in the Bering Strait, and a Spill of National Significance briefing and seminar. D17 also conducted a combined mass rescue operation (MRO) exercise with the Canadian Armed Forces, the Canadian Coast Guard, and Parks Canada to test our ability to respond to an Arctic cruise ship incident. This event occurred in the Beaufort Sea near the border between Canada and the United States and included the French expedition cruise ship *Le Commandant Charcot*, which tested their ability to meet International Code for Ships Operating in Polar Waters (Polar Code) requirements. The exercise involved evacuating 71 passengers and crew from the vessel to a Canadian island. Canadian and U.S. Coast Guard aircraft deployed to the location and delivered sustainment packages and simulated hoisting survivors. This exercise highlighted the logistical and operational opportunities and challenges faced when deploying U.S. Coast Guard HC-130's and MH-60's to remote Arctic locations.

To better prepare the region for the future, U.S. Coast Guard members also met with local partners to assess plans for a mass search-and-rescue response, engaged on a government-to-government basis with Federally-recognized Tribes throughout the Arctic and Western Alaska, and implemented layered cybersecurity measures throughout the maritime domain and shoreside infrastructure. Through these consistent engagements focused on developing and implementing contingency, safety, and security plans, the U.S. Coast Guard further illustrates why the Service is a valued instrument to protect and enhance community and port resilience in the U.S. Arctic region.

BUILDING ARCTIC CAPACITY

The ability for the United States to protect U.S. National sovereignty, safeguard our homeland, and meet the Nation's strategic priorities in the Arctic hinges on physical presence and access. U.S. operational presence and influence in the Arctic are founded on U.S. Coast Guard polar icebreakers. These ships provide assured, year-round access to the Polar Regions not only for U.S. Coast Guard missions, but also in support of critical activities of other agencies and Tribal Nations that protect key economic, environmental, and National security interests in the high latitudes.

The Polar Security Cutter (PSC) is a top acquisition priority for the U.S. Coast Guard and the Navy and is vital for the United States to continue to project sovereignty and protect National security interests in the Polar Regions. The PSC is the capability the Nation needs to ensure persistent presence and robust domain awareness in the Arctic and Antarctic regions. The integrated U.S. Coast Guard-Navy Program Office continues to work actively with the prime contractor to deliver

this critical capability. Continued investment is key to meeting our Nation's growing needs in the rapidly-evolving and dynamic Polar Regions.

The fiscal year 2024 President's budget also requests \$150 million to support the acquisition of a commercially-available polar icebreaker, including initial modifications, crewing, and integrated logistics support required to reach initial operating capability. The United States has vital National interests in the Polar Regions and the purchase of a commercially-available polar icebreaker will accelerate U.S. presence in the polar regions in the near-term and increase capacity in the long-term.

In addition to recapitalization of our icebreakers, investment in Arctic-capable U.S. Coast Guard surface and aviation assets, properly-trained and -equipped personnel, enhanced communication and domain awareness capabilities, and logistics resources are crucial to delivering U.S. Coast Guard services and advancing our security and sovereign interests in the Arctic. As outlined in the U.S. Coast Guard's 2019 Arctic Strategic Outlook, closing gaps in these areas requires a whole-of-Government approach, such as our partnerships with scientific research agencies, coupled with consistent investment to meet not only the challenges the Arctic presents, but also the opportunities.

CONCLUSION

The physical, operational, and geopolitical environment in the Arctic continues to change rapidly, driving demand for U.S. Coast Guard presence, influence, and services. The U.S. Coast Guard has served and shaped National security in the Arctic for more than 150 years and is central to a U.S. whole-of-Government approach together with partners to secure National interests in the Polar Regions.

The continued support of the administration and Congress for a modernized and capable polar fleet and increased U.S. Coast Guard Arctic capacity and capabilities will fortify the Nation's position in this age of Arctic prominence. U.S. Coast Guard leadership is essential in maintaining a coalition of like-minded partners to shape the Arctic domain as a region of strategic cooperation. Thank you for the opportunity to testify before you today and for your actions to support the members of the U.S. Coast Guard.

Chairman GREEN. Thank you, Admiral Gautier. I now recognize Ms. Brzozowski for her 5 minutes to summarize her opening statement.

STATEMENT OF CHRISTA BRZOZOWSKI, ACTING ASSISTANT SECRETARY, TRADE AND ECONOMIC SECURITY, OFFICE OF STRATEGY, POLICY, AND PLANS, U.S. DEPARTMENT OF HOMELAND SECURITY

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Thank you so much and good morning, Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and distinguished Members of the committee. I very much appreciate and I'm honored by the opportunity today to discuss the Department of Homeland Security's on-going efforts in the Arctic. All nations recognize the importance of the Arctic. Both our allies and our strategic competitors jockey for diplomatic, economic, and military advantages in a region with immense natural resources, trade, and geopolitical importance. Despite this competition, however, the Arctic is a space where the world can cooperate and work together to advance scientific research and ensure public safety.

As an Arctic nation, the United States must protect and safeguard the Arctic for the benefit of all. At DHS, we view Arctic security as homeland security, and we're dedicated to safeguarding the space. The brave men and women of the Department work tirelessly to secure Arctic lands and waters. U.S. Customs and Border Protection, for example, protect 15 ports of entry and 1,500 miles of land border working alongside U.S. Coast Guard and 33,000 miles of maritime border throughout Alaska.

We also have the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency, or CISA, who work closely with communities to protect

critical infrastructure and resources in the region. When disaster does strike, the Federal Emergency Management Agency, or FEMA, under the Department of Homeland Security, stands ready to help communities in need. Homeland Security investigations, or HSI personnel, protect Arctic communities against malicious actors such as transnational criminal organizations and nation-state actors. Of course, across air, roads, and railways, the Transportation Security Administration, or TSA, ensures safe travel throughout the Arctic.

To achieve this diverse mission, DHS works in close partnership with key allies to enhance our work across the region. For example, Secretary Mayorkas established the first-ever Tribal Homeland Security Advisory Council last year to strengthen our partnerships with the Tribal Nations. Moreover, earlier this year, the Department began work to establish a new Center of Excellence for Homeland Security in the Arctic to leverage the intellectual power of the U.S. academic community.

DHS continues to be a leader in developing and advancing the President's Arctic agenda, which, as we've heard, seeks to pursue an Arctic that is cooperative, stable, peaceful, and prosperous. The Department was a key contributor to the Implementation Plan for the National Strategy for the Arctic region and continues to work to enact these goals. This plan, established last month, highlights the importance of homeland security priorities in the Arctic agenda.

DHS has been a strong advocate for this holistic approach to Arctic security to highlight the need to safeguard Arctic communities from all hazards and to promote economic security. In this vein, I'm honored to echo President Biden and Secretary Mayorkas' announcement just this last Monday regarding the establishment of a DHS supply chain resilience center. The new center will enhance the Department's position to minimize disruptions from all hazards that threaten critical trade infrastructures and the supply of key goods and services to U.S. citizens in Alaska and across the country. Moving forward, DHS will continue to innovate and adapt to meet the evolving challenges that we see in the Arctic. We will continue building on our successes and partnership to advance Arctic homeland security.

To that end, I'm also proud to announce the Department will release our 2024 DHS Arctic Action Plan early next year in line with the administration's goals for the Arctic. The plan will build on the implementation plan just released by announcing specific DHS milestones that the Department will use to achieve our evolving security goals in the region.

So again, thank you to the committee and its Members for the interest in this very important effort and for the opportunity to testify. I look forward to your questions.

[The prepared statement of Ms. Brzozowski follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF CHRISTA BRZOZOWSKI

NOVEMBER 29, 2023

INTRODUCTION

Good morning, Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and the distinguished Members of the committee. Thank you for the opportunity to testify today regarding the Department of Homeland Security's (DHS or the Department) role, responsibilities, and on-going efforts in the Arctic.

Strategic competitors, allies, and like-minded partners increasingly prioritize the Arctic, contending for military, economic, and diplomatic advantages and influence in a region that is uniquely important due to its potential for resource development, waterway access, and global governance concerns. And yet, the Arctic is home to Indigenous Peoples and is a critical space for international collaboration, a region where the United States and our competitors could work together in scientific research and public safety efforts. As an Arctic nation, it is vital the United States protect and safeguard the Arctic for the benefit of all nations.

At DHS, we view Arctic security as homeland security and we are dedicated to safeguarding this space against all threats, including those posed by nation-states. DHS personnel work diligently, every day in the Arctic, providing critical physical presence in this remote part of the world and U.S. homeland. We also leverage our partnerships with allies to exponentially expand the impact of our efforts. We have found that by working closely with key partners like Alaska Natives and State and local governments, we can do more together than we could accomplish alone. DHS will strategically use these partnerships and other tools as we face future threats from the great power competition playing out in the Arctic.

As I will discuss in more depth, DHS relies on expertise from across its operational component agencies to safeguard the homeland. The Department—in concert with partners—plays a critical role to protect the Arctic from all hazards, ranging from environmental disasters to adversarial threats. Notably, the Department relies upon component agency expertise and experience in law enforcement, civilian defense and response, and region-specific technologies to advance Arctic security.

ON-GOING ADMINISTRATION WORK

As a key leader in enacting U.S. policy throughout the Arctic, DHS has been a major contributor to developing the administration's Arctic agenda. The Department wholeheartedly supports the President's policy goals to pursue an Arctic region that is peaceful, stable, prosperous, and cooperative, as articulated in the National Security Strategy.

In October of last year, the administration published the National Strategy for the Arctic Region. This strategy establishes an affirmative U.S. agenda for the next decade. The Department's input was critical in shaping this strategy's perspective on security and in advocating for a holistic approach that includes homeland security concerns. The Department was also a key leader and contributor to the Implementation Plan, published last month, for this National Strategy. The Department ensured that the Implementation Plan integrated homeland security equities throughout the four pillars to advance U.S. security interests, mitigate climate change impacts and protect the environment, develop economic interests, and advance international cooperation and governance. Specifically, my team co-led, with the Department of Defense, the effort to develop the Implementation Plan's security pillar. Due in part to DHS leadership and contributions, the administration's National Strategy and Implementation Plan both prioritize U.S. physical presence in the region, promote sustainable economic development, protect the Arctic ecosystem, and safeguard Arctic communities from all hazards—especially those hazards posed by our competitors.

The Department is a crucial leader in the administration's interagency work to guide and coordinate Federal Arctic policies. My office is a member of the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy's Arctic Executive Steering Committee, and we co-chair that committee's Bering Task Force, alongside the Department of the Interior and the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. We work closely with our interagency partners to protect this area that is, first and foremost, critical to the livelihoods of coastal communities including many Tribes. In years to come, this area will continue to grow in geostrategic importance for the United States and other nations because of its abundant natural resources, shipping routes, fisheries, and other future development opportunities.

ACCOMPLISHMENTS AND COMMITMENTS ACROSS THE DHS ENTERPRISE

DHS achieved several accomplishments in recent years and is deeply committed to our whole-of-DHS and whole-of-Government work. The Department's resources across the enterprise support multiple lines of effort, including: Tribal partnerships, law enforcement, civilian defense and preparedness, and innovation in Arctic technology. I would like to briefly describe our efforts and accomplishments for these commitments.

Tribal Partnerships

Developing local partnerships and cultivating local security capacity are crucial to enhance regional security and resilience. When the Department partners with communities and local governments on the ground and across our waters, we help build local resilience and capacity to all hazards. Under the Biden administration, the Department has strengthened one of our most critical partnerships in the Arctic—our relationship with Alaska Natives. On September 7, 2022, the Department established our first-ever Tribal Homeland Security Advisory Council that includes two representatives from Tribes from Alaska, among the 15 representatives of Tribes Nation-wide. Earlier this year, my office hosted our first-ever Tribal consultation sessions in-person in Alaska to understand the needs and concerns of Alaska Natives as we partner together in securing the region. DHS's component agencies also routinely host Tribal consultations, listening sessions, training events, and other forums to strengthen our partnerships with these important stakeholders.

We are committed to expanding and deepening our relationships with Tribal leaders and Alaska Native communities and value the roles they play in our homeland security mission.

Law Enforcement

As an Arctic sovereign nation, the United States' responsibilities are to protect our Arctic territory and interests throughout Alaska and ensure the rule of law across the region. The gravity of this role is of paramount importance to the Department. We are dedicated to protecting Alaska's 15 ports of entry; 33,904 miles of maritime border; 1,538 miles of land border; and 665,400 square miles of land. The U.S. Coast Guard is the lead DHS agency for protecting Arctic waters and coasts. The Department leverages its full range of expertise and authorities to protect communities throughout Alaska, relying upon multiple components, including U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP), Homeland Security Investigations, and the Transportation Security Administration.

Promoting lawful trade, travel, and economic security are key roles for the Department. Our employees enable safe travel through Alaskan land and maritime ports. The Ted Stevens International Airport in Anchorage is a key component of global trade. The airport is the world's fourth-largest for cargo throughput and second only to Memphis, Tennessee, in the United States. At this airport, DHS personnel work to protect Americans and our global trade partners against criminal and State-sponsored efforts to smuggle dangerous goods, such as illicit narcotics, and automatic weapon converters and silencers.

The Department's law enforcement officers in Alaska act as a force multiplier in the region. Given the national security threats posed by the People's Republic of China and Russia to the Arctic region, these enforcement efforts also support our national security priorities. Department law enforcement personnel will often coordinate with State, local, and Tribal authorities to identify, assess, and minimize the risk posed by foreign adversaries. A notable example is the coordinated Department response when two Russian nationals fled their government's military reservist draft last year. These Russian nationals claimed political asylum in a remote Alaskan island in the Bering Sea. Because of the strong partnerships among Tribal, State, and local entities, CBP worked with the Coast Guard and local law enforcement to respond in an extremely remote area of Alaska.

Civilian Defense and Preparedness

The Department's role in civilian defense and preparedness is unique, given the operational challenges of the Arctic. These challenges require proactive planning to enable communities to prepare, withstand, and recover from a range of potential hazards, both natural and man-made. In the coming years, planning will become even more critical as natural hazards are expanded by climate change and as regional competition from threat actors increasingly threaten our Arctic infrastructure. The Department engages with diverse partners, from local ports to academia, to identify and provide resources needed to enhance critical infrastructure security and resilience, and to identify and minimize damage from anticipated future events.

Given the harsh conditions of the Arctic, enabling critical infrastructure security and resilience is a “must” for Alaskan communities. Across the U.S. Government, we are working to help local communities address threats to infrastructure from climate change. At DHS, we are focusing on partnering with Alaskan Tribes to improve the cybersecurity of local infrastructure. To help support our partners respond to a wide range of emerging cyber threats, the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) and the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA) announced in September 2023 the \$18.2-million Tribal Cybersecurity Grant Program. This program will distribute funding and a framework to leverage CISA’s tools, expertise, and technical assistance to secure Tribal cyber networks and infrastructure against attacks.

When disasters strike, the Department is ready to help communities in need. In the fall of 2022, the historic Typhoon Merbok hit 1,000 miles of Alaskan coast, and DHS immediately took action. The U.S. Coast Guard coordinated the regional response with numerous Federal, Tribal, State, and local entities. Coast Guard teams deployed to remote villages to assess the damage to ports and fuel storage facilities and partnered with local residents and companies to remove oil debris and conduct clean-up operations. Following President Biden’s Major Disaster Declaration, FEMA responded with more than \$8 million in aid for Alaskans. DHS is vigilant and stands ready to help Americans in any crisis across the homeland.

Innovating for Arctic Technology

Meeting the increasing and evolving challenges in the Arctic requires that the U.S. Government invest in and develop technologies for this unique environment. The Department’s Science and Technology Directorate is creating a new Center of Excellence for Homeland Security in the Arctic to conduct research and develop new tools and technologies to enhance DHS situational awareness, improve communities’ resilience, expand collaboration across the Arctic-homeland security mission space, and provide key training opportunities for the next generation of Arctic homeland security professionals. This investment in a 10-year partnership and up to \$45 million in funding will enable us to harness the intellectual power of cutting-edge U.S. research and apply it to the complex issues facing the Department—specific to the Arctic.

DHS NEXT STEPS

Looking to the future, the Department will innovate and adapt to meet the evolving challenges throughout the Arctic. We will continue building on our successes and partnerships, expanding and augmenting our work to advance Arctic home security and implement our Nation’s Arctic strategy. I am proud to announce that the Department plans to release our 2024 DHS Arctic Action Plan early next year, in line with the administration’s goals for the Arctic. The Plan will include specific milestones for both DHS operational and headquarters components. The Plan will move the Department through concrete actions toward adapting and achieving our evolving homeland security priorities.

CONCLUSION

Thank you for your time and attention today as I have described, on behalf of the Department, our approach to advancing Arctic homeland security. The Department commits to continued focus and action to fulfill our homeland security mission through physical presence and strong local partnerships. By strengthening community resilience and preparedness throughout the region alongside key partners, we multiply the impact of our efforts. We will help protect the Arctic against all threats, including those posed by nation-state competitors, and meet the complex challenges our Nation faces in the region. I look forward to your questions.

Chairman GREEN. Thank you, Ms. Brzozowski. Thank you for being here. I now recognize Ms. Kenney for 5 minutes for her opening statement.

STATEMENT OF CHELSA KENNEY, DIRECTOR, INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS AND TRADE, U.S. GOVERNMENT ACCOUNTABILITY OFFICE

Ms. KENNEY. Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and Members of the committee, thank you for the opportunity to be here today to discuss GAO’s work on U.S. priorities and diplomacy

in the Arctic. My testimony focuses on key factors that affect the advancement of U.S. Arctic priorities.

Arctic-related issues have increasingly become global issues. In recent years, the effect of climate change, technological advancements, and economic opportunities have driven increasing interest and activity in the Arctic region. Escalation of great power competition between the United States, Russia, and China has also heightened tensions in the Arctic's geopolitical environment. Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 has further affected coordination among Arctic states and changed the security landscape, including seeing additional Arctic states join NATO.

The United States has articulated its Arctic priorities through a series of strategies since the 1970's. The most recent strategy was published in October 2022, and serves as a framework for addressing emerging challenges and opportunities in the Arctic. The strategy identifies four pillars spanning domestic and international issues from security to international cooperation and governance. Over 40 Federal entities inform the strategy, which illustrates the breadth of Federal entities with Arctic roles and responsibilities.

Our September 2023 report identified areas in which the Federal Government's management of U.S. priorities in the Arctic has been successful and what might limit future efforts. We spoke with Arctic experts and officials from Federal agencies, the State of Alaska, Alaska Native organizations, and other Arctic countries. Here's what we heard. First, what's working well? We heard White House-led coordination and Arctic Council engagement are providing important mechanisms for interagency coordination and global influence on Arctic issues. Notably, we heard that the Arctic Executive Steering Committee provides a mechanism for information sharing on interagency Arctic projects and strategy efforts. Further, other Arctic countries said the United States provides important expertise to the region on things like wildfire management, search and rescue, climate change, and sustainable development through its involvement in the Arctic Council.

Second, what's not working as well? Stakeholders said Federal agencies weren't meaningfully coordinating with the State of Alaska or Alaska Natives. Specifically, we heard that coordination was often irregular and last-minute, and input was repeatedly provided and not addressed. Inconsistent Alaskan input is an even greater issue, given another concern we heard, the limited awareness among Americans about Arctic issues and related U.S. activities. Stakeholders suggested that an increasing understanding of Arctic issues and their importance to the overall U.S. goals would be important to successfully implement the new Arctic strategy. They also questioned the depth of Federal agencies' understanding of the region, given that some agencies cover broad geographic areas from offices located far outside of Alaska.

Third, an area of opportunity. Stakeholders were supportive of the creation of the Arctic ambassador-at-large position in August 2022. They said it signaled the continued importance the U.S. places on Arctic issues and would provide a single voice for communicating about Arctic issues around the world. This position would be responsible for coordinating across the State Department and with the interagency and would be able to speak with foreign part-

ners on security issues, which is particularly important since security issues are excluded from the scope of the Arctic Council.

However, stakeholders also identified features they saw as critical to the ambassador position's success. These include developing a consistent position and formal office that would span administrations and provide greater institutional knowledge. They further suggested that ensuring the ambassador position had clear roles, concrete objectives, and the convening authority necessary to bring key parties together.

In closing, the Arctic region is of immense geopolitical significance to the United States, its allies, and to its strategic adversaries. Advancing U.S. priorities will require strengthened leadership and coordination across the Federal Government and with other Arctic countries. State as the Federal lead for Arctic diplomacy will play a key role in managing heightened security tensions in the region. In developing the ambassador position, it will be important to ensure it has the features needed to effectively lead State's coordination on U.S. diplomacy in the Arctic. Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and Members of the committee. This concludes my statement, and I look forward to your questions.

[The prepared statement of Ms. Kenney follows:]



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ARCTIC REGION

Factors That Affect the Advancement of U.S. Priorities

Statement of Chelsa Kenney, Director
International Affairs and Trade

Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and Members of the Committee:

Thank you for the opportunity to discuss our work on U.S. priorities and diplomacy in the Arctic as you examine Arctic security challenges. My testimony today summarizes our September 2023 report entitled *Arctic Region: Factors That Facilitate and Hinder the Advancement of U.S. Priorities*.¹

Current geopolitical trends indicate the Arctic region is growing more important to the United States and its allies and strategic adversaries. For example, record low coverage of sea ice has made Arctic waters navigable for longer periods and has increased opportunities for shipping in the region. We have also reported on the impacts of climate change on Alaska Natives, who have inhabited the Arctic region for thousands of years and whose ways of life are particularly sensitive to environmental changes.² In addition, the escalation of great power competition between the United States, Russia, and China has heightened tensions in the Arctic's geopolitical environment. For example, both Russia and China have developed Arctic strategies with geopolitical goals contrary to U.S. interests, with Russia seeking to consolidate sovereign claims and control access to the region and China aiming to gain access to Arctic resources and sea routes to secure and bolster its military, economic, and scientific rise. In September 2022 and August 2023, the United States monitored Chinese and Russian military vessels conducting joint exercises off the coast of Alaska in the Bering Sea and near the Aleutian Islands, respectively.

The United States has articulated its interests in the Arctic through a series of strategies since the early 1970s. The federal government published its most recent Arctic strategy in October 2022 and an implementation plan in October 2023. Together, these serve as a framework for guiding its approach to addressing emerging challenges

¹GAO, *Arctic Region: Factors That Facilitate and Hinder the Advancement of U.S. Priorities*, GAO-23-106002 (Washington, D.C.: Sept. 6, 2023).

²GAO, *Alaska Native Issues: Federal Agencies Could Enhance Support for Native Village Efforts to Address Environmental Threats*, GAO-22-104241 (Washington, D.C.: May 18, 2022); *Climate Change: A Climate Migration Pilot Program Could Enhance the Nation's Resilience and Reduce Federal Fiscal Exposure*, GAO-20-488 (Washington, D.C.: July 6, 2020); and *Alaska Native Villages: Limited Progress Has Been Made on Relocating Villages Threatened by Flooding and Erosion*, GAO-09-551 (Washington, D.C.: June 3, 2009).

and opportunities in the Arctic.³ The strategy identified four pillars (or priorities) spanning domestic and international issues: security, climate change and environmental protection, sustainable economic development, and international cooperation and governance. The implementation plan includes specific actions for agencies to take to address these four pillars. For example, the plan outlines actions for the Department of Defense and other federal agencies to take to deter threats and aggression in the region.

Numerous federal entities and interagency groups with varying roles manage U.S. Arctic efforts, but the Department of State serves as the overall lead for Arctic diplomacy efforts at an intergovernmental forum known as the Arctic Council and more broadly.⁴ Two offices take the lead on most Arctic efforts at State.

- The Office of Ocean and Polar Affairs within the Bureau of Oceans and International Environmental and Scientific Affairs focuses on the Arctic Council portfolio, and an official in this office serves as the U.S. Senior Arctic Official to the Arctic Council.
- The Office of the U.S. Coordinator for the Arctic Region was created in 2020 to coordinate the broader Arctic portfolio within State, including security-related issues. The Foreign Service Officer serving in the Arctic coordinator position left the office in June 2022. In August 2022, the President announced that the existing Arctic coordinator position would be elevated to an Ambassador-at-Large position. This change followed questions raised by U.S. lawmakers about State's structure for Arctic diplomacy and gaps between Arctic leadership positions.⁵

³White House, *Implementation Plan for the 2022 National Strategy for the Arctic Region* (Washington, D.C.: Oct. 18, 2023) and *National Strategy for the Arctic Region* (Washington, D.C.: October 2022).

⁴The Arctic Council, formally established in 1996 by the Ottawa Declaration, is an intergovernmental forum that includes the eight Arctic countries and involves Arctic Indigenous communities, among others. The Arctic countries are Canada, the Kingdom of Denmark (Denmark), Finland, Iceland, Norway, the Russian Federation (Russia), Sweden, and the United States. The focus of the Arctic Council is to promote cooperation, coordination, and interaction on Arctic issues, particularly those related to environmental protection and sustainable economic development. However, the council's charter expressly excludes matters related to military security.

⁵The Biden administration nominated Mike Sfraga, current Chair of the U.S. Arctic Research Commission, for this position in February 2023. The Senate has not held a confirmation hearing for this position, as of November 2023.

Our September 2023 report and my statement today address factors stakeholders identified that may facilitate or hinder the federal government's management of U.S. Arctic priorities, and State's role in managing those priorities.

We identified these factors, and State's role in managing these priorities, through our interviews with 31 stakeholders and review of Arctic strategies, State documentation, and other relevant reports. We selected the stakeholders to capture a range of perspectives and grouped them together on the basis of their affiliations, but their perspectives are illustrative only and cannot be generalized (see fig. 1).

Figure 1: Selected Stakeholder Groups Interviewed for Perspectives on the Federal Government's Management of U.S. Arctic Priorities

	Stakeholder group name (number of stakeholders)	Description of stakeholder group
	Department of State (9)	Representatives from nine selected State bureaus with Arctic roles, including eight bureaus and one office—the Office of the U.S. Coordinator for the Arctic Region, which is not located within a bureau
	Other Agencies (6)	Representatives from six other selected federal agencies—Departments of Defense, Energy, and Interior and the U.S. Coast Guard, Environmental Protection Agency, and National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration
	Experts (7)	Seven selected U.S. experts on Arctic issues
	Foreign Governments (5)	Government officials from five other Arctic countries
	Alaska Native Organizations (3)	Alaska Natives serving in three Permanent Participant organizations in the Arctic Council and representing other Alaska Native entities
	State of Alaska (1)	Representatives from one state government, specifically representatives from Alaska's Office of the Lieutenant Governor and other state government departments

Source: GAO (data); GAO (icons). | GAO-24-107192

More detailed information on our objectives, scope, and methodology can be found in our September 2023 report. Our work was performed in accordance with generally accepted government auditing standards.

Factors That Affect the Federal Government's Management of U.S. Arctic Priorities



Stakeholders identified five factors that facilitated and five factors that hindered the federal government's management of U.S. Arctic priorities. For example, stakeholders identified the following two facilitating factors:

- **White House-led coordination mechanisms support Arctic-related information sharing, projects, and strategy efforts.** White House-led coordination groups serve as mechanisms that support information sharing, interagency Arctic projects, and Arctic strategy efforts, according to stakeholders from four of the six groups. For example, a stakeholder from the State group explained that Arctic Executive Steering Committee meetings are a useful venue for State to provide briefings about current geopolitical issues that may inform U.S. activities in the Arctic and to learn more about other agencies' work in the Arctic for informational purposes.⁶
- **The United States exerts influence within the Arctic Council.** The federal government exerts influence in the Arctic Council through its expertise and engagement, according to stakeholders from five of the six groups. For example, a stakeholder from the Foreign Governments group said the federal government brings expertise to the council on various issues, including wildfires, search and rescue, climate change, and sustainable development. The stakeholder further noted that the more a country engages in Arctic Council projects, the more opportunities it has to build bridges with other Arctic countries and expand the Arctic community's knowledge on these topics.

Stakeholders also identified the following four hindering factors:

⁶A 2015 Executive Order established the interagency Arctic Executive Steering Committee to provide guidance to executive departments and agencies and enhance coordination of federal Arctic priorities. Exec. Order. No. 13689, *Enhancing Coordination of National Efforts in the Arctic*, 80 Fed. Reg. 4191 (Jan. 26, 2015).



- **Federal government coordination and partnership with Alaskans may not align with Arctic strategy principles.** Stakeholders from three of the six groups said that the federal government does not regularly or meaningfully coordinate or partner with the state government of Alaska or Alaska Natives, falling short of meeting certain principles of the strategy.⁷ For example, stakeholders from the Alaska Native Organizations group questioned whether agencies fully considered their input. One of these stakeholders raised concerns about federal agencies' inconsistent communication and last-minute engagement with Alaska Natives.



- **Some challenges to Arctic-related interagency coordination exist, and a lead coordinating group lacks authority to advance U.S. priorities.** Stakeholders from five of the six groups discussed Arctic-related interagency coordination challenges. For example, all seven experts we spoke with said the United States lacks an effective interagency coordination mechanism for Arctic efforts as a whole. The experts disagreed on where such a mechanism should reside, but several said the Arctic Executive Steering Committee has the potential to meet this need. However, the committee does not have the institutional convening or budgetary authority needed to advance U.S. Arctic priorities, according to stakeholders from the Other Agencies and Experts groups.



- **Americans have limited awareness of Arctic issues and federal government activities.** Stakeholders from four of the six groups discussed Americans' limited awareness of Arctic issues or a broader lack of awareness concerning federal government activities in the Arctic. For example, stakeholders from the Foreign Governments group questioned Americans' awareness of Arctic issues and said that the federal government and public may need a greater appreciation of the region to fully support the implementation of the strategy. However, one of these stakeholders said that attention from the White House and the Senate has helped to advance the U.S. Coast Guard's

⁷The strategy identifies four pillars, or Arctic priorities, and five guiding principles, two of which apply to Alaska Natives. The first principle is to consult, coordinate, and co-manage with Alaska Native villages and communities. According to the strategy, the United States is committed to regular, meaningful, and robust consultation, coordination, and co-management with Alaska Native Tribes, communities, corporations, and other organizations and to ensuring equitable inclusion of Indigenous Peoples. The fifth guiding principle is to commit to a whole of government, evidence-based approach, in which the federal government will work in close partnership with the State of Alaska, Alaska Native villages, local communities, and others.



Polar Security Cutter Program, which will enable the United States to increase its maritime presence in the Arctic.⁸

- **Budgetary and resource constraints limit the federal government's advancement of U.S. Arctic priorities.** Budget uncertainties, such as continuing resolutions, and resource constraints affect agencies' ability to plan, coordinate, and implement projects in the Arctic, according to stakeholders from four of the six groups. For example, a stakeholder from the Other Agencies group told us that without an annual appropriation, it is impossible to plan future travel and other events because the agency must develop incremental plans to align with the length of the continuing resolution. If relevant U.S. officials do not attend international events, it limits the federal government's ability to push back against strategic competitors who may be promoting interests that do not align with U.S. priorities for the Arctic region, according to a stakeholder from the State group.

Factors That Affect State's Management of U.S. Arctic Priorities and Elements to Consider for New Ambassador Position



Stakeholders identified three factors that facilitated and two factors that hindered State's management of U.S. Arctic priorities. Stakeholders identified the following three facilitating factors:

- **The Senior Arctic Official and staff effectively manage U.S. engagement and leadership in the Arctic Council.** The Senior Arctic Official and staff effectively manage U.S. engagement and leadership in the Arctic Council, according to stakeholders from five of the six stakeholder groups. Some of these stakeholders commented that institutional knowledge within the Senior Arctic Official position and office has facilitated U.S. leadership at the Arctic Council. Specifically, a stakeholder from the Other Agencies group explained that vast knowledge about the Arctic Council, including the history behind U.S. and Arctic Council decisions, facilitates U.S. efforts to promote its priorities on the council.

⁸In partnership with the U.S. Navy, the U.S. Coast Guard is procuring three heavy, polar-capable icebreakers ("Polar Security Cutters") to begin to address mission gaps and to expand U.S. presence in both polar regions. See GAO, *Coast Guard Acquisitions: Polar Security Cutter Needs to Stabilize Design Before Starting Construction and Improve Schedule Oversight*, GAO-23-105949 (Washington, D.C.: July 27, 2023).



- **An Arctic coordinator position has improved internal coordination across the broader Arctic portfolio.** The creation of a position to coordinate the broader Arctic portfolio has improved internal coordination within State, according to stakeholders from two of the six groups. Stakeholders from the State and Foreign Governments groups told us that the Arctic encompasses a broad set of issues, including energy, climate, defense, and sustainable development, that requires a broad range of expertise that spans the department. A stakeholder from the State group said that the coordinator position afforded the department insight into all bureaus, enabling the coordinator to understand how several Arctic issues are interrelated. For example, the coordinator identified how some Arctic security issues affect environmental discussions because of the position's broad reach across the department.



- **Separation between the roles of the Senior Arctic Official and the Arctic coordinator position supports U.S. engagement in the Arctic Council and on broader issues.** The existing State structure—in which the Senior Arctic Official focuses on the Arctic Council portfolio while an Arctic coordinator position coordinates the broader Arctic portfolio within State—supports U.S. engagement both in the council and on broader issues, according to stakeholders from three of the six stakeholder groups. For example, stakeholders from the Foreign Governments group said that the U.S. role in the Arctic is too big for any one person to cover both of these portfolios. One of these stakeholders stated that the growing number of non-Arctic countries with Arctic interests and Arctic-related issue areas indicates a growing need for engagement on Arctic issues outside of the Arctic Council.

Stakeholders also identified the following two hindering factors:



- **Gaps in leadership and in staff coordinating the broader Arctic portfolio have limited State's engagement outside the Arctic Council.** Gaps in leadership and in staff responsible for coordinating the broader Arctic portfolio have limited State's efforts outside the Arctic Council, according to stakeholders from four of the six groups. Since 2014, State has created three leadership positions with varying titles and roles to oversee a broad Arctic portfolio (see fig. 2). Stakeholders from the State group said that gaps in leadership led to fragmented efforts, with one of these stakeholders noting that State loses momentum on Arctic issues with constant changes in leadership and staffing. Moreover, stakeholders from the Foreign Governments group said that gaps in Arctic leadership limit U.S. engagement with other Arctic countries on broader issues outside of the Arctic Council.

For example, one of these stakeholders commented that there is no one person at State who can discuss broader Arctic issues at a working level. According to this stakeholder, the other six like-minded Arctic countries discuss broader Arctic issues together, and they wish the United States had someone who could engage in those discussions consistently.⁹

Figure 2: Timeline Showing Different Arctic-related Leadership Positions at State



Source: GAO analysis of publicly available information. | GAO-24-107192



- Prior positions coordinating the broader Arctic portfolio lacked convening authority.** Prior positions coordinating the broader Arctic portfolio had limited convening authority to, for example, bring decision makers together or quickly address informational needs, according to stakeholders from four of the six groups. For example, a stakeholder from the State group said that the prior Arctic Coordinator did not have a direct reporting line to the Secretary, which contributed to internal coordination issues. Some bureaus responded more slowly to requests from the Arctic Coordinator or the coordinator's office than they would to requests sent by officials with a direct line to the Secretary, according to this stakeholder.

Stakeholders from the State, Other Agencies, Experts, Foreign Governments, and Alaska Native Organizations groups viewed the 2022 announcement of the Ambassador-at-Large for the Arctic Region (Ambassador) position positively. Some stakeholders noted that the announcement served as a positive sign of increased U.S. interest in the region, while others focused on the implied benefits of such a position. For example, according to stakeholders from the Foreign Governments group, the announcement is a strong sign of the continued importance

⁹Stakeholders from the Foreign Governments group referred to the Arctic countries other than Russia (i.e., Canada, Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden, and the United States) as the "like-minded" countries.

that the federal government places on the Arctic, and such a position may raise the status of Arctic issues in the United States.

However, many stakeholders identified elements State and the new Ambassador should consider to manage U.S. Arctic priorities successfully going forward. These are:

- **Consistency in position title and corresponding office.** State should create a consistent position and office responsible for coordinating the broader Arctic portfolio that would span administrations, according to stakeholders from four of the six groups. Some of these stakeholders said that such a change would lead to greater institutional knowledge on the issues and support better working relationships across State, while others said that it would improve engagement with U.S. foreign partners.
- **A formalized office structure with a “deep bench.”** Stakeholders from three of the six groups highlighted the need to create a formal office structure to support the Ambassador. Creating this structure would include assembling a group of staff that can support the office’s efforts during a gap in leadership, an action one stakeholder referred to as “building a deep bench.” According to this stakeholder, State did not develop a plan for filling the leadership void prior to the departure of the U.S. Coordinator, and State has not conducted long-term planning for the Arctic office structure.
- **Clarity of Ambassador’s role within the department.** State should clarify the Ambassador’s role in relation to other bureaus and offices, according to stakeholders from three of the six groups. For example, a stakeholder from the Experts group stated that Ambassador-at-Large positions blur management lines within State and suggested that the Secretary of State define the Ambassador role in clear and specific terms, with concrete objectives. This stakeholder suggested that the Secretary of State require assistant secretaries to meet regularly with the Ambassador to discuss Arctic issues.
- **Greater authority within State.** The Ambassador should have greater authority to effectively coordinate within State, according to stakeholders from four of the six stakeholder groups. Some of these stakeholders assume that the ambassadorial title and the Senate-confirmed position will carry more weight than the prior Arctic coordinator position, and that such authority will provide the convening authority needed to bring everyone together. Other stakeholders focused on the need for the Ambassador to have clear

Rank and Reporting Line of Ambassadors-at-Large

According to a 2017 Congressional Research Service report, Ambassadors-at-Large generally rank immediately below assistant secretaries of State in terms of protocol, but their reporting line is not consistent. In 2017, two of the four Ambassador-at-Large positions at State reported directly to the Secretary of State while the other two reported to an Under Secretary.

Source: GAO analysis of Congressional Research Service report. | GAO-24-107192

and direct authority, such as that provided by direct access to the Secretary of State.

In closing, addressing Arctic-related issues, which have increasingly become global issues, will require strengthened leadership and coordination across the federal government and with other Arctic countries. State, as the federal lead for Arctic diplomacy, will play a critical role in managing heightened security tensions in the region going forward. However, State has taken an inconsistent approach to coordinating and managing the broader Arctic portfolio outside of Arctic Council work. It is important that State address the concerns identified above as it creates the new Ambassador position, which will be essential for leading U.S. efforts in international cooperation and governance in the Arctic.

Chairman Green, Ranking Member Thompson, and Members of the Committee, this concludes my statement. I would be pleased to respond to any questions you or other Members may have.

GAO Contact and Staff Acknowledgments

If you or your staff have any questions about this testimony, please contact Chelsa Kenney, Director, International Affairs and Trade, at (202) 512-2964 or kenneyc@gao.gov. Contact points for our Offices of Congressional Relations and Public Affairs may be found on the last page of this statement. Key contributors to this testimony include Godwin Agbara (Assistant Director), Amanda Bartine (Analyst-in-Charge), and Debbie Chung. Additional contributors to the prior work on which this testimony is based are listed in our September 2023 report.

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Chairman GREEN. Thank you, Ms. Kenney. Members will be recognized in order of seniority for their 5 minutes of questioning. An additional round of questioning may be called after all Members have been recognized. I now recognize myself for 5 minutes of questioning.

Admiral Gautier, you said, I think in your testimony you mentioned some of the port calls of the *Healy*: Iceland, and some of the other places. This question is really for both you and Ms. Brzozowski. In the context of the Arctic and the Antarctic, could you guys describe how soft power, how both the Coast Guard and DHS are involved in projecting the soft power of the country?

Mr. GAUTIER. Mr. Chairman, soft power in the Arctic and elsewhere is absolutely critical to advance the international rules-based order that we all enjoy. When you look at what our adversaries are doing to directly undermine those very norms, it's through alliances, partnerships, and the use of soft power in the Arctic and around the world that helps in best way in order to counter that.

So, for us, soft power includes things like the port calls that you explained. Whenever the Coast Guard cutter *Healy* gets under way in the Arctic, it's for science. It's for enforcing our own National interests and sovereign interests. It's also the soft power where we actually carry crew members from other countries on board. Then it's the port calls that we did in Tromso, Norway, and then Reykjavik, Iceland, and then elsewhere. It reinforces these relationships with the international community, with the values that we share, to directly counter the sorts of forces that are undermining those values.

Chairman GREEN. Please.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Yes, thank you for the question. As I'm looking across the expertise of our various components outside of the Coast Guard, what comes to mind first is the very vital and necessary relationships with the Tribal communities as sort-of, in essence, of maintaining that soft power. Some of the recent activity in that work or in that area has been the establishment of, as I said in my statement, a Tribal Homeland Security Advisory Committee. That is indispensable in getting the perspective of the local community where we might not have as robust of a physical presence in the areas where they are. Two Alaskan Natives are part of that community or of that advisory committee and lend their particular expertise and perspective.

I also think looking across to what our Federal Emergency Management Agency, or FEMA, does not only in the area post a disaster or helping to respond to something that has happened, but have a very robust presence with the allocation of grants and engagement with communities in a very proactive way to use their authorities, use their grants, and use their expertise to work with communities that may have been impacted by climate change, erosion, or their communities are needing to shift. So very robust grant programs in that area that can assist with the development of some of the soft power in the region.

Chairman GREEN. Thank you. Thank you. Admiral Gautier, if I were to ask you what is your No. 1 most-needed thing that Congress can help with, what would it be?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, we need your continued support to build out our polar security cutters and rapidly accelerate us into the future where we can have greater capacity for icebreakers.

Chairman GREEN. So, another cutter. Tell me, what is the, let's say 10 years from now, what is the total number needed 10 years from now?

Mr. GAUTIER. As a result of a Congressional requirement, the Coast Guard recently did an analysis and completed a report and submitted it to Congress on the fleet mix that we think we need, to answer your question. The answer that we have is 8 to 9 icebreakers. That's a mix of heavy icebreakers like the *Polar Star* and

the polar security cutters that we're building now and medium icebreakers like the *Healy* that have shallower draughts and can get into tighter spaces and shallower areas.

Chairman GREEN. I have been fortunate enough in my Congressional delegation travel to be on a Norwegian icebreaker and to be on a Finnish icebreaker. They seem to be able to build those pretty inexpensively. What are your thoughts on leasing versus owning?

Mr. GAUTIER. We've been considering leasing for actually a number of years and we are really, really challenged in order to do that for a couple of different reasons. The first is that an icebreaker, a security cutter, is essentially a U.S. sovereign warship. It's a military vessel. When we lease a vessel, we're really challenged to have the kinds of presence and authorities capabilities that we would like to have on a leased vessel.

Chairman GREEN. That makes complete sense.

Mr. GAUTIER. The other is that there's some rules for scoring that just on the budget that make it really impractical.

Chairman GREEN. Well, thank you for sharing that. I now recognize the Ranking Member for his 5 minutes' questions.

Mr. THOMPSON. Thank you very much. Admiral, the Congressional Research Service has noted that commercial fishing, shipping, oil and gas development, and tourism in the Arctic is on the rise as the ice decreases. One of the things we see is in other parts of the world, China and Russia, kind-of exploits certain opportunities. Do you see that as those areas as potential for exploitation on the part of Russia and China?

Mr. GAUTIER. I do, Ranking Member, and that is because Russia and China have said so. If you read the Chinese Arctic strategy, they describe, as we have here, that an opening Arctic region provides opportunities for resource exploitation, minerals, oil, fishing that they are interested in. Russia views the Arctic as absolutely essential to its own vital interests for maritime trade. They've declared that just recently that they intend on operating shipping in the Northern Sea route year-round. So, we do expect that there will be increased activities from Russia and China in that area. We aim with the international community to ensure that that's in accordance with international rules and norms and lawful.

Mr. THOMPSON. Thank you. Ms. Kenney, you talked a little bit about the ambassador-at-large's job and the fact that it is at this point lacks confirmation. Do we have, to your knowledge, someone who is filling that role on a temporary basis, or how is it operating at this point?

Ms. KENNEY. Thank you for the question. The ambassador-at-large position is, according to the State Department, something that would elevate the prior U.S. arctic coordinator position, which is currently vacant. But this vacancy, inconsistent staffing at this particular position, has been a problem for a long term. Before, the U.S. coordinator served for 2 years, but recently vacated this summer. Prior to that, there was a several-year lapse, and then there was a special representative that served in the same function.

Basically, there has been different positions with different levels of seniority, different responsibilities within the State Department that have intermittently provided this kind of leadership. However, we heard again from stakeholders that it was really important that

we were able to find consistent leadership for this particular role within the State and, of course, across the interagency and with our Arctic partners that had the right convening authority, the right line of effort, line of coordination to the Secretary of State, and a deep bench, really developing the institutional knowledge to be able to provide that kind of broad arctic leadership over a period of time.

Mr. THOMPSON. So, I hate to butcher your name, but Ms. Brzozowski.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. I have a feeling you're talking about me.

Mr. THOMPSON. Yes.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. You got it. You got it.

Mr. THOMPSON. I got it?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. You got it.

Mr. THOMPSON. OK. I have that Mississippi challenge, too.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. There's a——

Mr. THOMPSON. Yes, right.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. There's a silent ZO.

Mr. THOMPSON. Well, based on what Ms. Kenney just said, is that pretty much your assessment of how things are working right now?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. I really would have to defer to my Department of State colleagues, but I can say that the nomination of the new position is something DHS certainly supports. DHS, is—I'm sorry, and State Department's role in just providing that convening capability, the diplomatic role that is played by that position is absolutely indispensable.

Mr. THOMPSON. Yes. Well, you talked a little bit about coordinating with people in that region. From your perspective, tell us a little bit about how that works.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Yes, absolutely. You know, as you look across the mission of DHS, you're seeing as you know, a wide scope of responsibilities. So, we have, I think, the most obvious presence in the region is going to be the U.S. Coast Guard. A very visible presence with, I believe, over 2,500 individuals in that region. This is something where you see them in the maritime ports of entry, but also in the community. In addition, we have Customs and Border Protection and other types of law enforcement present. So, these are going to be entities and Transportation Security Administration entities that you're seeing at airports or at other ports of entry.

Then, I guess, another sort-of very visible way of engaging with the communities and having these partnerships is through our Cyber Security and Infrastructure Security Agency, or CISA. These are the entities that are responsible for working with State, local, Tribal, territorial, as well as Federal stakeholders and Tribal communities to understand the vulnerabilities of critical infrastructures in the region. So, pipelines or cables of these maritime and other types of ports of entry. So, any kind of critical infrastructure and working with those communities that is really their bread and butter to understand the capabilities and to develop actions to strengthen the resiliency of those critical infrastructures and prepare for what mitigations and responses could be, should there be either a physical or cyber challenge.

Mr. THOMPSON. Thank you much. I yield back, Mr. Chair.

Mr. HIGGINS [presiding]. The gentleman yields. I now recognize myself for 5 minutes for questioning. Admiral Gautier, I had the great honor of sitting next to the legendary Representative Don Young for 6 years in Congress. For some reason, Don liked me and took me under his wing, literally on my first day in Congress. I sat next to him for 6 years. He was my friend. Every year we had an opportunity, and any of you that knew Don Young, he was quite passionate about the State of Alaska and the significance of the Arctic region. Every year, during NDAA debates and appropriations discussions, we would talk about the need to grow and enhance and strengthen our response capabilities and patrol capabilities in the Arctic and the need for icebreakers.

Don shared a wealth of knowledge with me that he had garnered over the course of over 4 decades of service in Congress. I came to understand that he was completely accurate with his assessment. We must have American-built and American-owned, American-flagged and -piloted icebreaker vessels.

Don also clarified that there is a place for leasing as well. That in the enhancement of our ability to respond, especially for the Coast Guard, but to include the Navy, there is a place for leasing, but we must have ownership. I have never quite had it explained with such clarity as you stated, Admiral, regarding the response capabilities and the authority of an actual Coast Guard-owned or U.S. Government-owned vessel and in international waters, what that means and signifies, should we face threat, which we face increasing threat from the Chinese and the Russian presence in the Arctic.

To focus on the polar security cutters, if I may for a moment, Admiral, I would like to ask you, you are aware that the shipyards of America play a significant role with developing our fleets for the Coast Guard and the Navy. Bollinger Shipyard is a Louisiana-based shipyard. They work with the Coast Guard on many contracts, and they recently took over the PSC, the Polar Security Cutter contract. They took great risk assuming that contract, a massive amount of risk from Halter Marine in 2022. The contract was awarded in 2019 and in my opinion, it has many challenges. Not only does the contract include production of a vessel that has not been built in 50 years, but inflation over the last 2 years has caused an incredible rise in production costs.

So, how is the Coast Guard working with a United States shipbuilder like Bollinger to help them perform within the parameters of the reality of inflation to produce a much-needed icebreaking vessel, a polar security cutter? How is the Coast Guard working with the shipbuilder?

Mr. GAUTIER. First Congressman, there's a lot of affection for Congressman Young in the United States Coast Guard. We would not be who we are in Alaska today without his enduring support. In terms of shipbuilding in Bollinger, very closely with Bollinger, we knew that we would have challenges with this particular acquisition. We haven't built a heavy icebreaker in the United States for 50 years. This is the most complex Coast Guard cutter that we will have ever built, and we knew there would be risks and challenges in the process.

With Bollinger taking over or taking ownership of the shipyard, we're encouraged at the progress now and the acceleration that they're providing in that particular contract. I was just down there with some of our senior acquisition professionals in October to look at what's going on. They're making progress on the detailed design, and we hope and we believe that construction will be able to begin in 2024.

Mr. HIGGINS. You have a high level of confidence that it would be able to move forward effectively without delay?

Mr. GAUTIER. I don't want to in any way gloss over the really substantial challenges in this very unique vessel type, but we really do believe that we're building a ship and we're building a shipyard at same time.

Mr. HIGGINS. Yes, sir. Thank you, Admiral, for your response. You can look forward to a great cooperative effort with my office and this Congress. I now recognize my colleague, Mr. Correa, for questioning for 5 minutes.

Mr. CORREA. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I want to thank the witnesses for being here today, your good testimony. Admiral Gautier, I just want to say over the years, I come to appreciate the good work the Coast Guard does. I don't think people realize that not only are you in the Arctic, you are in the Antarctic as well. You are as far out as North Korea enforcing the laws in that area when it comes to trade. You are in the Caribbean doing some anti-narco interdiction. You are all over the place.

We talk today about the Arctic. We talk about the fact that we are trying to build another cutter icebreaker. In my opinion, we are never going to equal the assets Russia or China have or can produce. What are the multipliers out there we can rely on? Ms. Brzozowski, you talked about soft power. Let's think about playing not checkers, but chess here. The Antarctic, the Arctic, the Americas, we have two wars going on right now, possibly a third, and we have got to take care of the home base, the Americas. I think this is what really we are talking about here.

I keep hearing the echoes here of we haven't invested enough to protect our Northern Border. We haven't done enough to protect the resources. Frankly, given every bet we got to cover around the world, it is going to be challenging to do all the above. But you know what? I think the American public expects us to do our job, and that is to make sure we protect Alaskan territory, American water rights, resources in that area, as well as all the way to Antarctica.

General question to you, Admiral, what is the resource multiplier here? How do we get it done today, not tomorrow? And tomorrow as well?

Mr. GAUTIER. Thank you for your kind remarks about the Coast Guard, Congressman. The *Polar Star* is en route from Hawaii to Sydney, Australia, for a quick port call before going into Antarctica. So, that's happening as we speak.

So, you know, a lot of this is being driven by this number 54, 55 Russian icebreakers. To put that in context, they're employing those icebreakers differently than we might think. Many of those icebreakers are local, and they are there just to break out their harbors, break ice in their harbors to manage their own maritime

trade. We actually have a fleet of Coast Guard cutters, small Coast Guard cutters, in our Eastern and Great Lakes ports that do that very thing too.

Mr. CORREA. So, we can't compare apples to apples, so to speak, in general terms. But again, how do we make sure we are doing our job in terms of the resources, the multipliers? We have other assets they don't have. Please continue.

Mr. GAUTIER. So, we don't need parity, sir, with Russians. We do need more. We do this by aggressively managing our risk portfolio. Eleven statutory missions in the Coast Guard, we operate globally. But the homeland is our most important place that we operate here, which is why we have a razor-sharp focus on our key missions that save lives, like search and rescue, like law enforcement, like boating safety. Keeping our maritime transportation system open is absolutely critical.

That's why when we talk Arctic, there's a much broader portfolio of Coast Guard needs that we have in terms of building our offshore patrol cutters. We just launched the first offshore patrol cutter in Florida a couple of weeks ago, making sure that that acquisition moves forward smartly.

But, Congressman, I'll share with you our major challenge and benefit here is people. The men and women of the Coast Guard are absolutely extraordinary.

Mr. CORREA. Yes, they are.

Mr. GAUTIER. We are challenged with a historic recruiting problem that's similar to at the other services are happening.

Mr. CORREA. I am going to ask a written question. I am going to submit a written question to you on this area. Ms. Brzozowski, I am going to do the same, but I am going to ask it here, which is what are the soft power multipliers as we really look at the Americas here as kind-of not our, you know, not sovereign territory, but our backyard? How do we take care of this?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Yes, I mean, it really is a fantastic question. I'll answer briefly here and happy to respond for the record. But, you know, I think the best force multipliers are going to be to, yes, build on the presence that we have with both personnel and assets in the region, with partnerships. So, the partnerships I had mentioned before with the Tribal, but also with State, local, the array of actors.

Then the second would be I really am hopeful that our new Supply Chain Resiliency Center is going to allow us in the Arctic but elsewhere, to just work smarter to identify supply chain challenges, risks, vulnerabilities that can get consumers and American citizens the goods that they want through supply chains that we trust, that align with our values, and that sort-of support our domestic industry. DHS has vast authorities in that regard. So that center is really going to be the hub for how we can take very much a closer look at the supply chains that feed every critical infrastructure and make sure that they're working efficiently and that they're promoting U.S. jobs and livelihoods.

Mr. HIGGINS. The gentleman yields. The gentleman from Florida, Mr. Gimenez, is recognized for 5 minutes for questions.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. In terms of the Arctic, I look at it as Russia and China maybe versus the

United States and Canada. Can you tell us about our Canadian assets and our friends, what kind of assets they have in the Arctic?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, our Canadian friends are also in a major shipbuilding phase that's both the Canadian Coast Guard, which is a civilian force, and the Canadian Navy. They, through their shipyards, are building ice-capable sort-of frigate/corvette-sized vessels. One actually accompanied the Coast Guard Cutter *Healy* during circumnavigating North America last year. They are very much invested.

But, Congressman, I'd also extend that effort to our partners in Scandinavia and in the other Arctic Council nations. We are all feeling the same pressure to keep the Arctic safe and secure, and they're all making investments with us.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Are the investments made by our friends also, do you think that they are sufficient? Do they need to be stepped up? Obviously, our efforts need to be stepped up too. We have two icebreakers, and one you said is broken right now, not operating, or?

Mr. GAUTIER. The *Healy* had had some steering issues. Those are fixed and it's on its way to the Panama Canal. So, we have two operational.

Mr. GIMENEZ. How many do you think the United States is going to need in order to protect our interests in the Arctic region?

Mr. GAUTIER. We're going to need 8 to 9, sir. A combination of polar security cutters, heavy, and then a medium icebreaker, in order to provide us persistent presence in the U.S. Arctic, off Alaska, on the Atlantic Arctic. Then that also includes a presence for Antarctica to recapitalize so we can continue to provide our presence and our missions down there.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Are there plans to build these ships or this is a wish for?

Mr. GAUTIER. We're planning on it, sir. We have asked in the fiscal year 2024 budget for money to advance polar security cutter No. 3. We're in the preacquisition phase for the medium cutters, the Arctic security cutter. But in the mean time, we know we need to field capability more quickly. So, in the 2024 budget, we've asked for money to purchase a commercial icebreaker, which is a medium icebreaker. So, in the near-term we can have immediate presence and in the longer term, we can do the sorts of missions that we need to do in the Arctic.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Well, the Chinese have shown a willingness and a proclivity actually to operate large fishing fleets around the world. Are they starting to do the same up in the Arctic region where we should be?

Mr. GAUTIER. Not yet, sir. There is an international agreement that prohibits fishing in the central Arctic region that's north of the Bering in international waters. But we know there's interest. Fish stocks are moving north and there have been some discussions within that body that governs that on doing some test fisheries to understand how that might be regulated. But China as well as other countries are going to be interested in fishing there when that's permitted.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Oil exploration, are there any treaties that govern oil exploration in the Arctic region?

Mr. GAUTIER. I think there's some mention. So, there is no treaty that governs the overall Arctic region other than UNCLOS, the U.N. Convention of the Law of the Sea. It is a basin ocean, essentially. I think there is some mention of oil exploration in UNCLOS. I don't know that off the top of my head, though.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Because that would concern me. That would be a place where Russia obviously is a big oil, but any country can go into the Arctic and just plop down a rig and start drilling if they want?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, there are already lines that are drawn under the U.N. Convention for extended continental shelves for that sort of resource exploitation. There's some disagreements in those and there's some friction there. But I think if there were oil exploration production, it would be done on already-sanctioned international outer continental shelf that are related to nation-states, if that makes sense.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Who are those nation-states?

Mr. GAUTIER. The United States, through—all the Arctic states, sir. Russia, Canada, the United States through our extended continental shelf.

Mr. GIMENEZ. Fair enough. OK. I yield my time.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize the gentleman from Louisiana, Mr. Carter.

Mr. CARTER. Mr. Chairman, thank you. Yesterday, I had the pleasure of hosting a field hearing in my home State of Louisiana. I would like to personally thank the Chairman of the subcommittee, Mr. D'Esposito, and Ranking Member Thompson, for joining me in Louisiana for what proved to be a very successful field hearing. Climate change is being felt world-wide with several and severe natural disasters like hurricanes, droughts, and wildfires. Admiral Gautier is the part of the world where I am from.

Mr. GAUTIER. I was a captain in the Port of New Orleans. Gautier sounds great to me.

Mr. CARTER. Gautier sounds good, fantastic. How does the Coast Guard actively incorporate climate change considerations into its operational strategies? What specific measures or initiatives are in place to address the anticipated impacts on maritime and coastal security, sir?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, recognizing that climate change was just going to change the way the Coast Guard had to do business, we drew up a strategic plan for that that covers three different efforts. The first is we need to be able to respond to more and more frequent natural disasters. Typhoon Merbok. A typhoon hit Alaska last year, right, in southwest Alaska, and did quite a bit of damage there. We need to be prepared for that at greater capacity.

The other is that we need to build more resilience into the United States Coast Guard in terms of our shore infrastructure, our piers, our facilities ashore. We have plans to do that. The third one is that we're a regulator, and actually we lead the delegation to the International Maritime Organization that negotiated in the international community carbon caps on international shipping by 2050. So, as a result of that, through U.S. efforts with the Coast

Guard delegation, we negotiated that by 2050, international shipping needs to be zero carbon.

Mr. CARTER. Excellent. How is the Coast Guard collaborating with other agencies to adapt to the changing climate and ensure effective responses? One of the things that we talked about in New Orleans yesterday was making sure that these interagencies were working together and not duplicating efforts and making sure that we're complementing each other in our effort to counteract climate change and bring the greatest results.

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, through a lot of different ways. You know, in terms of what our goals are going to be internationally, we work through the State Department as their lead in those efforts. Here domestically, I mean, we look at FEMA as being the preeminent Federal organization in terms of building National resilience, and so we follow, you know, we take the FEMA recommendations when we're building our own, our new facilities and so on.

National Weather Service and NOAA is absolutely critical in their advancing in the science and forecasting and helping us understand what storms in the future and what Coast Guard impacts might be.

Mr. CARTER. Not on this matter of climate change, but I do want to give a particular shout-out to the Coast Guard and the Corps of Engineers for working with my office in Louisiana. As you may or may not be aware, there was a tragic accident a year or so ago where several children found themselves finding an attractive nuisance to cool themselves off in the river. The report was recently completed, and we will be working on remedial measures to protect young people or anyone from the allures of the Mississippi River and the danger that it poses. So, I just want to say thank you to you guys for being very diligent and moving forward on that.

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, sir.

Mr. CARTER. Ms. Kenney, how does these agencies coordinate to make sure that you leverage each other's work and not duplicate efforts?

Ms. KENNEY. Thank you for the question. So, there are a number of domestic- and internationally-focused coordination efforts that exist across the Government. It's really important because for the development of the National strategy, we saw over 40 Federal entities actually contributed to that. So, there really is a whole Government approach. There really is every agency is really an Arctic agency when you think about the support that they're providing to Alaska.

So, we found a couple of things, you know, we heard positive feedback from the Arctic Executive Steering Committee and their role in coordinating the domestic agencies and interagency projects and their development of the strategy. We again heard positive feedback about the U.S. participation in the Arctic Council in terms of working with our other Arctic states.

Mr. CARTER. Fantastic. In 20 seconds, I need each of you, if you can, just tell us you are here with us now, we are very grateful for your presentations. Tell us, what can we do as a committee to improve interagency coordination with the Arctic? Is there some silver bullet, if you will, that sitting before this committee, if there is

something we can do to assist each of you more, what might that be? A second each.

Ms. KENNEY. One thing we pointed out was continuing to monitor the implementation of the National strategy. There are some long-term investments that will need to be made and some agencies that will need to work together to be able to make those kinds of investments. It's important that we're monitoring the implementation, ensuring those agencies have the resources.

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. I would have to say the moving forward with the ambassador-at-large position. It's not a DHS direct DHS equity, but certainly one that I think my colleagues at the Department of State would appreciate.

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, not just support for building ships, but it's also supporting our incredible people and the shore infrastructure that we need to operate those ships.

Mr. CARTER. Very good. Thank you. I yield back, sir.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Mr. Pfluger, the gentleman from Texas, for his 5 minutes' questions.

Mr. PFLUGER. Thank you, Mr. Chairman, for this hearing, and I thank the witnesses for your service and for being here. I will start with the topic on China and just really kind-of digging in. I mean, I think it has probably already been discussed to some degree, but their presence in the Arctic poses obviously a threat and their ambitions throughout the world and especially in that region. Just in August of this year, 11 Chinese and Russian military vessels were identified in the region. In 2022, 3 PLAN ships were found sailing with 4 Russian vessels. So, this partnership, this alliance, whatever you want to call it, is obviously concerning back to 2021. The warships, the Chinese warships that were in the U.S. economic zones, exclusive economic zones, another example of that.

So, I will start with Assistant Secretary Brzozowski, looking at Xi Jinping and him expressing ambitions to make China a polar great power by 2030. Much like space, I kind-of look at this domain as a little bit of a new frontier in the Arctic, at least. From what DHS can see, at what pace is the PRC increasing its military profile in the Arctic?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. This is an urgent question and one that we're very much focused on at the strategic level at DHS, where I am at the Office of Policy. So, we'll bring our full set of authorities and resources and expertise of various components to bear against this. But I think it's maybe important to mention something that hasn't been discussed during this hearing yet, and that's the role that we see our authorities under Team Telecom as well as the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States. So those authorities and those interagency structures that allow us to have a National security review of foreign, be it a license application for a telecommunication system or telecommunication supply chain, or to potentially have an acquisition that could result in a proximity of a malicious agent to a military base, or an insertion of a particular type of malware into a critical component that could then be put into a control system for a water treatment plant. So, those are authorities that I think are very unique and ones that we exercise with a great amount of diligence.

Mr. PFLUGER. If I may just kind-of looking at the pace that the PRC has increased their military profile, any response on that in the Arctic?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. I don't know that I'd comment on sort-of the pace of whether we've seen that increase or decrease specific to the Arctic, but I think it would be fair to say that the pace across the country has increased. So, I would imagine that it's the same pace in the Arctic.

Mr. PFLUGER. Admiral Gautier.

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, the PRC military has expanded its capability at an absolutely extraordinary rate. So, in the surface action groups that you mentioned, this is now a routine. This is the third time where we've seen these combined China-Russia surface action groups that have patrolled through the U.S. EEZ, in the Aleutians. We have not seen Chinese military vessels north of the Bering, although they do have two icebreakers, civilian as, you know, state-owned icebreakers, Xue Long 1 and Xue Long 2 that operate both in the Arctic and Antarctic. We know that those plans are going to be expanded. They articulate sort-of common values in their operations in the Arctic. We know that elsewhere they do not necessarily follow those.

Mr. PFLUGER. Thank you for that. I will quickly go to some of the coordination between the Coast Guard and other services, including the Air Force and maybe the prioritization, the domain awareness, the issues that can you in the last 50 seconds kind-of speak to the collaboration with other services and anything that you may need to continue that cooperation.

Mr. GAUTIER. So, Congressman, the response to these sorts of threats are meeting presence with presence to make sure that these engagements are lawful. We absolutely have a very tight relationship with the Department of Defense, the United States Navy, in particular. Our District 17 headquarters out of Juneau, Alaska, is very tightly integrated with Alaska Command, the three-star command under US NORTHCOM. When the Navy responded to the Surface Action Group this summer, there was a Coast Guard cutter nearby, and that had all been scripted very carefully through the joint DoD Coast Guard relationships that we have.

Mr. PFLUGER. Thank you for the service. I will briefly say, in my district there are some joint programs that are run under DHS, but with Coast Guard involvement. Recently, just a couple of days ago, using a MQ-9 drone, they were able to rescue 4 folks in a vessel in the Gulf of Mexico using that joint mentality. So, quite admirable on that. I know that is an everyday occurrence because you guys are doing that around the world. But thank you for that, and I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Mr. Thanedar for his 5 minutes of questions, the gentleman from Michigan.

Mr. THANEDAR. Thank you, Chairman Green, and thank you, Ranking Member Thompson, for holding this hearing. I thank all the witnesses here for your testimony. I certainly appreciate the hard work of the men and women of Coast Guard in keeping us safe.

I know and understand the need for the icebreakers. My question to you, Admiral Gautier, as you wait for these icebreakers, what are you doing to prepare the Coast Guard in terms of infrastructure on the shore, aircrafts, personnel so we will be effective as these icebreakers are acquired?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, Congressman, we do talk a lot about ships, but there's a whole heck of a lot of other things that the Coast Guard is doing in Alaska with Congress's enduring support there. We've recently converted our fleet of fixed-wing aircraft from C-130 Hs to Js. Much more capable, much longer range.

We're building housing in Kodiak to support and piers in Kodiak in advance of homeporting 2 offshore patrol cutters that are being built in Florida, homeported in Kodiak. We're home porting 6 fast response cutters. We've gotten 3 there now. We're going to home port 3 154-foot-long corvettes in Alaska. We're building out the shore infrastructure in Seward and Sitka and Kodiak and Ketchikan in order to homeport those there. So, we're doing a lot. But it is really contingent on the focus of Congress and the enduring support because it will continue to cost a lot of money in order to do this.

Mr. THANEDAR. Talking about cost, what does a good-sized commercial icebreaker cost?

Mr. GAUTIER. We've requested \$150 million in fiscal year 2024 budget to build a U.S.-, to buy a U.S.-built commercial icebreaker.

Mr. THANEDAR. OK. Going back to my days as running businesses, I know there was a talk about leasing as opposed to buying. This is something of an on-going need the Coast Guard would have to have these icebreakers. Why would you even consider leasing them as opposed to owning them and having full control over such operation?

Mr. GAUTIER. We had examined leasing because there was Congressional interest in us leasing. I think two lessons came out of that. It's really that again, these are naval vessels. They're warships. They need to operate with the full sovereignty of the United States of America, which leads us toward purchasing. Then there's some rules in terms of leasing that require us to front the money for the entire of that lease that makes it really impractical.

Mr. THANEDAR. Yes, I agree. I totally agree. What other needs besides the icebreakers? What other things Coast Guard needs to continue its operate?

Mr. GAUTIER. Sir, we intend on homeporting the 4 polar security cutters in Seattle, Washington. We've begun a multi-phased effort in order to dredge, deepen, renew the piers, build the shore infrastructure that we need to do there. We have asked for money in the fiscal year 2024 budget in order to complete the Phase 1 and begin the Phase 2 part of that. So, the shore infrastructure actually is just as critical as the icebreakers themselves.

Mr. THANEDAR. OK. Last, I keep worrying about concern about the morale of the Coast Guard, our ability to retain and attract Coast Guard workers, men and women who work so hard under some of the toughest work conditions. What is being done to ensure that we compensate them well, they have in terms of whether it is compensation, money, mental health services, other issues? What has been done there?

Mr. GAUTIER. Well, thanks for recognizing the great people in the United States Coast Guard and for voicing your support for that. We are in a full-scale recruiting effort here in order to close an almost 10 percent gap in our enlisted work force. We've asked money from Congress in the fiscal year 2024 budget in order to support recruiting, in order to support the kind of monetary awards and incentives that we need in order to retain people, especially in critical rates, like in the cyber rating and other ratings like that. But as you allude to, we really need to provide top-notch medical care, and that includes mental health for these individuals, child care centers, and the kind of workplaces and tools that they need to do that. We've presented all of this to Congress in the 2024 budget, and we'd really appreciate helping that matter.

Mr. THANEDAR. Thank you, Admiral. I yield back,

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Mr. Gonzales, the gentleman from Texas, for his 5 minutes' questioning.

Mr. GONZALES. Thank you, Chairman. Thank you for all the witnesses for being here today. I think it is a very important hearing that we don't talk enough about. I actually recently got back from Antarctica, and one of the things that I saw there, and I would like to tie it into the Arctic region, is I visited McMurdo Station and there is a very kind-of a, single entry point. There was a Chinese base that essentially every aircraft is going to have to fly near. That just highlights the fact of the growing Chinese presence throughout the globe, Antarctica, certainly.

But the question I have is for the admiral, is there are serious concerns with a growing Chinese presence in the Antarctic region capable of monitoring air traffic and collecting intelligence. Admiral, are we facing similar concerns in the Arctic region?

Mr. GAUTIER. I think we're keeping a laser-sharp focus on those potential developments in the Arctic region. Not in North America, right? Not in the Canadian Arctic, the U.S. Arctic, or the Danish Greenland Arctic. But certainly, I think we can expect that kind of growing influence as Russia and China have operated a lot more closely together.

Mr. GONZALES. I would like to build off of that. Maybe not necessarily the permanent infrastructure, but can you talk to a little bit about maybe joint exercises or things that kind-of show a force that China or Russia in particular, have done, whether it is in the Arctic region, or to highlight their ability to fight in an Arctic environment?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, certainly. I think in this environment that we're in, where Chairman Xi and Putin have expressed an unlimited relationship, right? We are seeing growth in how Russian and Chinese militaries are operating together. The latest example of this is the flotilla of vessels, the surface action group of 11 or so vessels that transited through the Aleutian in the U.S. exclusive economic zone. We are now seeing that every summer.

Mr. GONZALES. Excellent. Thank you. My next question also for you admiral. The Port of Nome in Alaska recently announced its plan for an extensive expansion that would make the port the United States' first deepwater Arctic port. While the project is being undertaken through a combination of Federal, State, local,

and private funds, the port has already publicized that it will be capable of docking military vessels. Does the Coast Guard have a plan to utilize this port for operations in the Arctic?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes. Well, as the Army Corps of Engineers did the feasibility study, we worked very closely with them to provide them things like what the drafts of our icebreakers would be and advise them as they completed that study. I think as this construction moves out, the Coast Guard absolutely values additional infrastructure and the high latitudes that we can use. I think in this case, we would absolutely use the Port of Nome for refueling stops, doing personnel exchanges, as a logistics supply base, and those sorts of things.

Mr. GONZALES. As we get closer to this being built out and completed, I know this committee would certainly be welcome to hear any thoughts as far as what resources, whether the Coast Guard needs directly or indirectly, in order to be able to access that port for all the tools that you need. My next question is, does the Coast Guard anticipate needing additional deepwater ports in the Arctic region?

Mr. GAUTIER. Our intent is to operate the Polar Security Cutter fleet out of a home port in Seattle, Washington. We do have plans if we do get this commercially-available icebreaker for home porting somewhere in Alaska. We view this infrastructure as really helping with logistics, right? Not home porting, not basing. So, if additional port locations were developed, the Coast Guard would certainly use those for our operations.

Mr. GONZALES. I think that is spot-on. Going back to my trip that I recently took to Antarctica, the takeaway for me was the logistics, the supply chain logistics that are just needed. I think the Coast Guard is going to play a critical role in that. Once again, whether it is permanent or whether it is temporarily helping out this Arctic region, please keep us informed on what we can do to make sure that all the infrastructure is there, but also the Coast Guard has the resources it needs.

We have talked about icebreakers and some of these things for years and years. It seems like we have finally got that moved in the right direction. But please keep us posted on what other tools you need to be successful.

Mr. GAUTIER. Certainly.

Mr. GONZALES. Thank you, Chairman. I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize the gentleman from New York, Mr. Goldman, for his 5 minutes' questions.

Mr. GOLDMAN. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. Thank you for calling this very important hearing. Thank you to our witnesses for being here. I believe this area of interest is becoming more and more important as we are seeing geopolitical issues pop up with the connections between Russia, China, and Iran. I want to talk a little bit about the importance of the Arctic region in connection to those threats that we are seeing more and more of.

Russia is only 55 miles away from Alaska in the Arctic, and we obviously are seeing a tyrant, anti-democratic tyrant, Vladimir Putin invade Ukraine. If he is successful in defeating a democracy, certainly our understanding in Congress from the experts in the

administration, is that this will just be the first step. So, there is a real National security risk as it relates to Alaska. Now that China is also getting involved in the Arctic, there are even more threats.

I think it is not something that has gotten enough attention. I guess, Admiral, from your perspective in the Coast Guard, what are the additional threats that you are concerned about and what additional resources or authorities would be helpful to combating those threats?

Mr. GAUTIER. So, certainly they are the geostrategic threats from Russia and China that you've talked about. We talk about climate change as being an incredibly substantial threat. Regardless of where people view that, it is certainly opening up the waters in the Arctic to more human activity. So, we're seeing things like cruise ships, expeditionary cruise ships with under a couple of hundred passengers that are routinely operating, going all the way up to the North Pole. We're seeing more traffic, vessel traffic through the Northern Sea route as Russia exploits their mineral resources, liquefied natural gas, and that sort of thing. So, with more ships, that means more the threat of potential accidents and incidents, even oil spills there. The Coast Guard is working with our partners to be prepared for those sort of eventualities.

Mr. GOLDMAN. Have you had discussions with administration partners that you can reveal in an unclassified setting about the increasing concerns related to Russia's aggression in Ukraine and how that might have an impact on the Arctic?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, sir, we are absolutely joined. We're a member of the intelligence community, so we get the same intelligence everybody else does. We are joined at the hip at the Department of Defense and the component services and interoperable as a military service with their operations. Absolutely, we're communicating.

Mr. GOLDMAN. What resources or what actions do you think would be helpful for Congress to take to support your work in the Arctic in both ensuring our national security and also making sure that we are taking full advantage of the region?

Mr. GAUTIER. We ask for Congress's enduring support in our recapitalization, in our shipbuilding, and the shore infrastructure that we need in order to have the kind of presence to provide that strategic deterrence in those locations. So, we know we need to build 8 to 9 polar security and medium icebreakers. We know that we need to build out Seattle as a home port. We need to purchase a commercially-available icebreaker, and that's in the fiscal year 2024 budget so we can get after this problem set soon.

You know, as a great Nation, we really need to be able to respond at the time and place of our desire, and the Coast Guard needs to advance and grow our assets in order to achieve that.

Mr. GOLDMAN. My last topic that I want to address, and I don't know if Ms. Brzozowski is the best person to answer this, but the Arctic Council was created 25 years ago and has paused because of Russia's invasion in Ukraine. I am wondering if you could give an update on what the status of the council is and whether it is resuming its work without Russia.

Mr. GAUTIER. Is it OK if I take that question—

Mr. GOLDMAN. Yes.

Mr. GAUTIER [continuing]. Congressman? So, I say this because the Coast Guard supports some of the working groups under the Arctic Council, with the State Department leading. So, the Arctic Council resumed its convenings and its discussions after the chair—Russia had been the chair during the invasion—after they stepped down, and Norway took over in May. Those discussions in the Arctic Council, absent Russia, have continued. Russia has been permitted by the Arctic Council to participate below the principal level and only in writing, not in meeting attendance.

Mr. GOLDMAN. Thank you. I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. Excellent question. I now recognize the gentleman from Mississippi, Mr. Ezell.

Mr. EZELL. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I appreciate it has been a great conversation today about the Arctic region and the Coast Guard strategy to secure the area. We know that the Russians and the Chinese are bad actors, and what is going on up there is a great concern of ours. To combat this, we must roll out the next generation of polar security cutters as soon as possible. And I am proud that the most advanced ice breakers in the world are being built in South Mississippi.

Ultimately, these vessels that my constituents are constructing will help secure the Arctic region. Admiral Gautier, as we say in South Mississippi, the initial contract for the polar security cutter program was awarded to VT Halter in November 2022. VT Halter Shipyard was acquired by Bollinger, and they continued the work on the program.

Vice Admiral, thank you for visiting there recently. I really appreciate you going by my district. Can you tell us a little bit about the confidence that you may have in our shipyard program down there?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, to start out, we knew that there were going to be challenges with this acquisition, given the novelty and the complexity of this particular ship. Having just been down there, though, with some of our chief—I am not an acquisition guy, but we had our chief acquisition folks there. I think they're encouraged at the actions that the shipyard has taken to accelerate the time line and to move forward on some of the key things. So, it's stuff like we really need to have a detailed design complete before they can begin construction in total. They've made a lot of progress since the shipyard turned ownership over.

In order to accelerate the construction of the vessel, the Coast Guard has authorized the construction of some test hull sections, and that gives the shipyard some build proficiency and build some lessons in how they can build the rest of the ship. They built one of those, and they're building the second, and I think that's going well. We do have some hurdles. I don't want to paint an overly rosy picture. The shipyard has indicated issues in the contract in terms of the time delivery, which is currently 2025, and the cost, and we're in negotiations with them to understand what the courses of action forward might be.

Mr. EZELL. Very good. I understand that the previous shipyard was owned by a foreign, was a foreign company which owned it, which required some additional oversight in the operations. Are

you finding it easier to deal with this shipyard that is owned by the Americans——

Mr. GAUTIER. Well, I——

Mr. EZELL [continuing]. Versus a foreign company?

Mr. GAUTIER. My acquisition colleagues would warn me to be very professional because there are rigid rules under the Federal acquisition regulations. We treat everybody the same and have, you know, have that requisite oversight. That being said, we have a long-term relationship with Bollinger. They are building our fast-response cutters. They have built almost every modern class of patrol boat that we have in the inventory, and those are high-quality, well-performing ships.

Mr. EZELL. Thank you very much. The Coast Guard testified earlier this year that its mission in the polar regions will require 8 to 9 polar icebreakers, which we have had some discussion about this morning already. This is an increase. Given the new estimate, could you clarify how this breakdowns in terms of class, such as the heavy or medium icebreakers?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, so we're doing further analysis to understand just where that breakpoint might be. But I think we're thinking 4 to 5 heavies, 4 to 5 mediums, and you know, it's going to swing one way or the other, depending on what our concept of employment, concept of operation looks like. The importance of the mediums is that they get access places where the heavies can't go, and we really expect those to be less expensive, so it'll be a better deal for the taxpayer.

Mr. EZELL. Very good. Given the current absence of the capable polar cutters, to what extent are the National security cutters or the fast response cutters able to operate in the polar regions?

Mr. GAUTIER. Less so the fast response. Well, I say the polar regions, we are homeporting 6 fast response cutters in Alaska. Those will operate in the Gulf of Alaska and southeast Alaska predominantly. But when we're talking north of Nome, north of the Bering Strait, those won't be operating there. Although, but the National security cutters, we have actually brought through the bearing and operated in the Chukchi Sea. We did that on occasion once so we could accompany the Chinese icebreaker Xuelong in there to provide presence along the maritime boundary line. In the summer months when there's no ice, we can operate up there.

Mr. EZELL. Thank you, Vice Admiral. Thank you all for being here today. It has been a great discussion, and we will continue to do everything we can to support the Coast Guard and your mission. So, Mr. Chairman, I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Mr. Garcia from California for his 5 minutes of questioning.

Mr. GARCIA. Thank you, Mr. Chairman, and appreciate this important hearing. Thank you to all of our witnesses. We know that our Nation and our National interests face many threats and challenges, whether it is from competitors like Russia and China, climate change, or changing economic trade, all of which have been talked about today in this hearing. We know that in the Arctic, all these factors and challenges come together in unique ways. President Biden, of course, has adopted a National strategy for the Arc-

tic region and establishing an ambassador at large for the Arctic as well. All very positive steps and moves forward.

Now, our Coast Guard is critical in our operations and presence in the region, and so I look forward to our committee working together in a bipartisan way to support their mission. I will also add that I served 8 years as mayor of Long Beach and the Coast Guard was just a critical piece and partner to us in every way at our ports and security, even as an economic driver in our city. So, we are very grateful to our Coast Guard and our partnerships back home in Long Beach and in California.

Now, we know that we are quickly falling behind both Russia and China who are really trying to dominate the region and often in collaboration with each other. As Russia modernizes upwards of 50 bases along the Arctic, it continues to build its fleet, of course, as we know. The Coast Guard, of course, is operating at a reduced level in comparison to clearly these what I believe are aggressors in the region. We know that new vessels are under construction, but behind schedule and already over budget. This is concerning to all of us, but we know it is not enough also just to count hulls. Every vessel needs complicated infrastructure and trained personnel to support deployments.

Admiral, I just want to just first to you, from various reporting, it seems that not only are Russia and China both investing heavily to control the region, but their partnership and collaboration continues to increase. So, what are we doing to try to increase our presence and really focusing on this collaboration? Because I think it is a collaboration that is especially concerning.

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, you said two keywords Congressman, that's presence and collaboration. So, we've been talking about fielding more capabilities to provide in that persistent presence that we need in order to counter any kind of malicious behaviors in that particular region. Our plans in expanding our fleet, our plans hopefully to get a medium icebreaker purchased here in the 2024 budget are part of that.

But really key here are the partnerships of like-minded nations through the Arctic Council, through the Arctic Coast Guard Forum, the North Pacific Coast Guard Forum Atlantic. You can tell we have a number of venues in the United States Coast Guard and both on the policy side and operationally that really strengthens the resolve and the relationships between these countries against the kind of malicious behaviors that we might encounter.

Mr. GARCIA. Can you also just walk us through more broadly what the United States stands to lose from like a National security perspective if Russia and China consolidate and essentially try to box us out of the Arctic?

Mr. GAUTIER. Well, a lot. I mean, it's really challenging to contemplate. I mean, we are talking Alaska here. We're talking Arctic. Our United States is an Arctic state. So, to kind-of be boxed out of our own neighborhood is really a scary thing to be thinking about. In the broader Arctic, you know, similarly, the Arctic historically has just been inaccessible. Now that it's becoming more accessible, we absolutely need to make sure that it's free, open, peaceful, and, you know, benefits everyone.

Mr. GARCIA. Finally, Admiral so again, as former mayor, the Long Beach and Los Angeles ports are the largest container sea-ports in the United States, critical ports to the rest of the country. There are also ports in the Arctic. So, we know that the encroachment is happening, of course, all across the Arctic, but especially also nearing ports in the Arctic. So, what are the impacts or concerns we have related around ports and our interests around trade and having these ports operational as far as we see them from both a National security perspective and economic perspective?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, thanks. I know that the California port complexes well as the operational commander over all Coast Guard operations in California. So, port security and assuring the maritime transportation system for the Coast Guard, other than search and rescue, is absolutely preeminent for us. So, when we look at U.S. infrastructure in the area, certainly the Port of Anchorage is the preeminent port there. The Coast Guard has a sector, western Alaska, headquartered out of there. That is their No. 1 job, to preserve that as sort-of the entree into the remainder of the State by road or by other means.

But when we talk about other port infrastructure, it's just notable how much investment that Russia is doing along their Arctic coast. They've announced their intent, the Northern Sea route, the waterway there that brings goods and services through the Bering Straits from Russia, they've announced their intent to have that operational now year-round. They are going to employ icebreakers to help do that. But that tells you what the importance is to their economic and national security on the Arctic.

Mr. GARCIA. Thank you very much. I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize the gentleman from New York, Mr. D'Esposito, for his 5 minutes of questions.

Mr. D'ESPOSITO. Well, thank you, Mr. Chairman, and good morning, everyone. In addition to serving on the House Homeland Security Committee, I also have the honor of serving on Transportation and Infrastructure. Acting Assistant Secretary Brzozowski, Homeland Security plays a vital role in securing the transportation sector in the United States of America. This includes airports, marine ports, maritime ports, those that facilitate the flow of goods and people across this world, as well as oil, gas pipelines, and freight rail networks. Can you describe the posture of DHS equities in protecting the infrastructure that supports life in the American Arctic?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Thank you so much for your question. I was chomping at the bit almost to jump in on the last question, because that infrastructure, beyond sort-of the very visible port infrastructure that we see in sort-of big maritime facilities is just so vital. Even just in Alaska, we are looking at, of course, big infrastructure and maritime ports like the Port of Alaska, but also airports that are also a very visible presence. Then the things that you may not see but are indispensable to the transportation, but also other types of energy and networks in Alaska and basically to the rest of the United States. Things like undersea cables, where you see 98 percent of the world's internet and other types of communications are not in that region, but sort-of in those undersea cables where you see them running through that region. Also, things like

the Arctic Trans-Alaska Pipeline, which is an 800 miles network that provides fuel, gas, other types of energy resources, not only to the region, but to the continental United States.

So, our posture in the region is going to be sort-of spanning the totality of the DHS mission set. Maybe I'll group it best into the authorities that we have for preparing and engaging with stakeholders. These are where we have our transportation security officials working with State and local on putting in place regulatory and non-regulatory regimes for security all the way down to the physical presence and the law enforcement that you see through Coast Guard and Customs and TSA and then spanning into the response and recovery that you see through FEMA.

Mr. D'ESPOSITO. OK, thank you. Obviously, I know we have discussed and there have been questions asked that Alaska and the Arctic, they present a unique operating environment and they present unique threats. It is clear that the administration has failed to make sure that we have what we need to protect our homeland in other places throughout this country. Are you confident in the Department that it has what it needs to protect the homeland in those regions?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Thank you so much. It is our No. 1 priority to ensure that we are protecting not only those regions, but the regions throughout the United States. The diversity of, as I said, the missions as well as the authorities, and the expertise that span DHS, we're constantly working to enhance those and improve those. I would say, in the Arctic region, as we're looking at these critical infrastructures that you mentioned again, that the ports and then some of these supporting critical infrastructures that are indispensable to energy networks, transportation networks, health and safety networks, we're aggressively employing the tools that we have in the entity's, both people presence, as well as the partnerships and other types of capabilities.

Mr. D'ESPOSITO. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Mr. Menendez, the gentleman from New Jersey, for his 5 minutes of questioning.

Mr. MENENDEZ. Mr. Chairman, Mr. Ranking Member, thank you for convening today's hearing on U.S. Arctic strategy. To our witnesses, thank you for being here. I want to build on the questions my colleagues have asked throughout today's hearing on the new polar security cutters that the Coast Guard is procuring. While I am concerned about the delays that have plagued the process so far, I want to talk about what comes next once those vessels are built, keeping them operational.

In a challenging environment like the Arctic, I want to be sure that our polar security cutters are able to receive timely service and repairs. Admiral, how is the Coast Guard accounting for future maintenance needs in the design process of the new polar security cutters?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, we start the program, we basically bake that in into the overall cost. We have a life-cycle cost analysis that we do that includes things like the regular operation and maintenance, but also the deep-level maintenance in terms of dry dockings and things like that.

Mr. MENENDEZ. Appreciate that. Just to follow up on that, one thing I want to make sure we are all considering is the infrastructure afforded by current shipyards. For example, as a point of personal pride, in New Jersey's 8th Congressional District, we have the Bayonne Dry Dock, the largest dry dock in the Nation, which received a small shipyard grant earlier this year to improve their technology and infrastructure, allowing them to continue providing crucial repair services to vessels in the U.S. armed services. Admiral, what is the Coast Guard doing to ensure that our current ship repair facilities will be able to meet the needs of the new polar security cutters?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, great question. The U.S. defense industrial shipyard base is absolutely crucial, not just to the Coast Guard, but United States Navy, NOAA, and other Governmental entities. So, having the kind of facilities that are there in order to conduct not just the shipbuilding, but the dry docking and the long-term maintenance is absolutely crucial.

We don't have a heck of a lot of resilience in that regard, I have to say. What I'll cite here is that Secretary Del Toro, Secretary of Navy, has been very forthright in this, in announcing a Government shipbuilding council. That announcement was made at U.S. Coast Guard yard in Baltimore, Maryland. So that tells you, No. 1, that we are very tightly integrated with the Navy in this particular problem set. No. 2, we would benefit from more capacity and capability there.

Mr. MENENDEZ. Absolutely. I had a chance to visit Bayonne Dry Dock with the Secretary and so continuing further collaboration to ensure that we have that capacity, have the resiliency. Just one last question to build off of that. I am curious to hear our witnesses' thoughts on how increased maritime activity in the Arctic will increase demands on our ship repair facilities. This question is open to any of our witnesses. How are we incorporating the demands for repairs from both defense and commercial vessels operating in the Arctic in our strategic planning? Open for any witness.

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, so maybe amplifying the earlier answer. There are just a certain number of dry docks that are going to be able to handle the polar security cutter. It is an extraordinarily heavy vessel. It's the largest ship that the Coast Guard will ever have, has had to date in the inventory. So, there are just a few shipyards that can handle that. Quite frankly, we would be in direct competition with the United States Navy on the dry docking of their hulls as well, which is why we coordinate with the Navy in order to try to deconflict those sorts of maintenance periods. Having more options, having more resilience in that shipyard, in the suite of shipyard capabilities would only be beneficial.

Mr. MENENDEZ. I agree. That was just in competition with the Navy. You also have increased, you will see increased commercial activity there as well, which will be an additional burden on our existing dry dock facility. So, look forward again to working with you on that.

In the remaining time, building off my colleague Representative Goldman's line of questioning, I want to make sure we are prepared for the potential consequences of increased Russian and Chinese cooperation. I was particularly troubled by reports of Russian

tankers without ice classification shipping oil through the Arctic to China. This question is for any of our witnesses. What actions can the United States take to pressure Russia and China to reduce the environmental risk they are posing to the Arctic with these unprepared tankers?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Maybe I'll start off at a strategic level, very briefly. One of the sort-of wide-ranging actions that our Secretary has recently taken is to initiate what he called a 90-day sprint. This is to take a really close look at the totality of actions that are arising from this increased activity of the PRC in the area. So, the Arctic is 1 of 6 of the focus areas for this sprint. We're looking at a variety of evolving threats and things like critical infrastructure, increased traffic, protecting our critical infrastructure in the area, and a host of other things. So, that is one thing where we're inspecting current processes and evolving threats, and we'll have more information on that early next year about some of those specific findings.

Mr. MENENDEZ. I appreciate that. As we think about that increased activities, just making sure that we are prepared to hold both nations accountable should a catastrophe happen in the Arctic. With that, Mr. Chairman, I yield back. Thanks so much.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Mr. Brecheen of the great State of Oklahoma for his 5 minutes of questioning.

Mr. BRECHEEN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I appreciate you all being here. Probably this is going to be unfair because I am going to lay before you the holistic approach of spending for our Nation. I am doing that because as we stand before a Nation that is facing within the next 10 years insolvency on mandatory programming and our discretionary spending, which you all are a part of. One hundred percent of our discretionary spending right now is borrowed money. We had a \$1.7 trillion Gross National Deficit as of last year, and that was our total spend for discretionary spending.

So, every dollar we are spending, inclusive of the budget for the Coast Guard and so many other things because of mismanagement of finances for the last 40 years, probably more so than any other time in our Nation's history, we don't ask the questions anymore how we pay for this? So, how do we pay for \$3 billion worth of icebreakers when it is borrowed money from our kids and our grandkids? Can you make a strong case with what is happening with our Southern Border? I think we spent over, under the Trump administration, for 400 miles of rehabbing of border wall security, it cost \$15 billion.

So, almost \$3 billion for these icebreakers is a significant amount of money in comparison to what we could do to secure our Southern Border. So, I guess what I am doing is help make a case with a Nation that never talks about how do we pay for this, how do we pay for this and make the case for why is it such a high priority?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, Congressman, I acknowledge the deep relevance of your question. My response is that the Coast Guard is actually an investment. When we look at only costs, it sort-of masks the fact that every day, the Coast Guard actually saves the Nation money. When I was captain of the Port of New Orleans and we had something bad happen on the Mississippi River and I

closed the river down, it was \$270 million in lost revenue to business for every day that that river was shut down.

I think as we are going to see more cruise ships operating more deep draft cargo vessels, including oil and liquefied natural gas vessels operating in the high Arctic, including, eventually, the transpolar route over the North Pole, perhaps, mitigating those types of accidents is actually going to be a cost saver for us. Then when we look at the geostrategic impacts of additional presence by Russia, additional presence by China, what costs are we deferring that we're then going to have to pay in the long term? The Coast Guard has actually been advocating for polar capabilities for the past 20 years. These costs have been deferred.

Mr. BRECHEEN. So if I could just take it further. Is there not any way, I know you have the *Healy*, correct, that is a medium-sized icebreaker, and I am not for sure about the other total assets. Tell me what happens if within another 5 to 10 years, after a major investment, things start changing and we start seeing these routes are no longer possible any longer? I mean, it wasn't so long ago that these routes weren't possible just because of—and what happens if a freeze reinitiates there and we have this investment and now things go the opposite direction? Can we not make do with what we have and without it being an impediment to us?

Mr. GAUTIER. Wherever there's going to be ice, we're going to need an ice-breaking capability to give access to the places that we need to go to provide Coast Guard services. You know, thinking about your last question, our one heavy icebreaker was built in 1976. I think that's pretty darn good value for the buck. The Coast Guard is doing a 5-year service life extension plan in little chunks during the summer months so that that icebreaker can travel down to Antarctica in the winter to do its job.

Mr. BRECHEEN. I come from a heavy equipment world where some of my best machinery was old machinery, if you take good care of it. So, you are indicating that there is some means of expanding the lifespan. Have you looked at beyond 5 years, maybe, taking this equipment and expanding the life span beyond that time frame?

Mr. GAUTIER. That ship goes into the yard for a period of months once a year and will for 5 years. We're 3 years in, and that's very successful at this point. That will extend the service life of the Coast Guard cutter *Polar Star* until the first Polar security cutter is going to be in service. So, that ship will be with us for a while.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I now recognize Ms. Titus from Nevada for her 5 minutes of questioning.

Ms. TITUS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman, and thank you to the witnesses. You know, in Nevada, we have a number of Native Tribes who are very much engaged in the culture, the politics, the economics. Just recently, they were very involved in having Avi Kwa Ame declared a National monument. I know there are a number of Tribes in Alaska that you have worked with, Ms. Brzozowski. I think within the Department of Homeland Security, we have a Tribal Homeland Security Advisory Council. Can you tell me how much they have been engaged in setting policy in the Arctic and if you think they may become kind of a permanent voice in the Arctic Council?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. Thank you so much for your question. I have to actually give credit to my colleagues. I'm new on the job, so all the good work goes to the folks that have been here much longer than I have. But you're absolutely right. The establishment of the Homeland Security Tribal Advisory Council, which does include 2 of the 15 members coming from the Alaskan region, is one of many advisory councils that the Department of Homeland Security but other Government agencies have. In particular, that group was indispensable in providing input and insight into the development of the DHS implementation plan that we're going to be using to guide our implementation of the national strategy for the Arctic region. So, it's not a body in name only, but rather really providing key insights into the needs of the community, things that need to be prioritized, as well as livelihoods and sort of priorities of those communities.

I also did want to note here that with 40 percent of all Federally-recognized Tribes, as I understand it, being in Alaska, a physical presence in that area is indispensable. My team actually travelled, folks from my team had travelled to the region earlier this year to get a sense of the community needs and requirements as we develop this implementation plan, which is in the final stages.

I want to also give credit to our Federal Emergency Management Agency. Not only are they integrated into communities around the world, but in Alaska in particular, looking down to see, make sure I get their name right, but they actually have developed and recently released a National Tribal Strategy, which is a strategic roadmap to better help Tribal Nations to prepare for and then respond to emergencies. That's not specific to Alaska, but again, world-wide.

Then also last year, President Biden appointed an enrolled citizen of the Choctaw Nation of Oklahoma as FEMA's very first National Tribal advocate. So, sort-of incorporating these viewpoints from the top down and baking them into the policies that will guide our actions is something that we're very committed to.

Ms. TITUS. Admiral, do you consult with the Tribes as you build out the infrastructure needed?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, ma'am. We consult with Tribes as just an everyday course of business, and it is not by exception, it's routine. An example of that is we have this standing operation called Arctic Shield in Alaska, which is another way of saying how we deliver Coast Guard services throughout Alaska. Just in this calendar year, we've reached 91 different communities. Many of them travel in remote locations in Alaska to do things like commercial fishing, vessel safety inspections, training, and education on boating safety. We'll inspect oil tanks in those communities that they use to run their infrastructure to make sure that they're in good shape and they won't leak. Right now, actually, we are in the process of looking at shipping lanes across the north coast of Alaska, and those are in direct consultation with Tribal communities.

Ms. TITUS. Thank you. I am glad to hear that involvement. Another area where I think you can find needed involvement is you mentioned that more and more traffic is in the Arctic. You got more tourists, you got more business, you got more defense. When

people come, they leave trash. What are y'all doing about protecting this area from being trashed?

Mr. GAUTIER. In terms of international shipping, the Coast Guard works very closely through the International Maritime Organization. They're actually meeting in London right now to set a high standard for vessels to prevent trash, to prevent oil discharge. In fact, just a few years ago, under the Coast Guard's leadership, we advanced something called the Polar Code, which are special shipping regulations which prevent things like overboard discharge of grey water to make sure that we maintain a pristine Arctic environment.

Ms. TITUS. Plastic? Keep plastic out of there.

Mr. GAUTIER. Plastic as well, absolutely.

Ms. TITUS. You want to add to that or?

Ms. BRZOZOWSKI. No, thank you.

Ms. TITUS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman, I will yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentlelady yields and appreciate those questions. I now yield to Mr. Crane, the gentleman from Arizona, for his 5 minutes questioning.

Mr. CRANE. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I want to say thank you to the panel for showing up today. I appreciate all the information that you are bringing to this committee on challenges in the Arctic. I want to start with you, Admiral. What are your greatest concerns and your observations of the activity, the collaboration with Russia and China in the Arctic region?

Mr. GAUTIER. So, the greatest concern is that we know how Russia and China behave outside of the Arctic and that that sort of behavior might be imported inside the Arctic. I mean, to date, China has access through their icebreakers, and they're doing scientific examinations there. But, you know, as we see fishing stocks moving forward, as we see it more attractive to do resource exploitation there, the challenge that we have is that we'll see similar behaviors from China and Russia that we see elsewhere in the world, which is directly undermining the global norms that we all enjoy.

Mr. CRANE. Yes. Thank you, Admiral. As a former sailor myself, I just wanted to acknowledge and say thank you for your service. I know you spent a long time serving this country, and I think I speak for all of us on the panel when we say we appreciate it.

I do want to go back into something you were talking about a second ago. You were not only talking about some of the needs that you have for some equipment like these icebreakers that we have spent a lot of the time talking about. But I also want to talk about something you mentioned, the people that work for you and within the Coast Guard, and some of the recruiting issues that you guys are having. I want to see if, I want to ask your opinion, why do you think you are across the military having so many recruiting issues?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes. So, as you said, we share this challenge with the other military services. COVID had a huge impact on things, and it wasn't really until COVID hit that we saw this dip in recruiting and retention for whatever reason. A lot of this would just be supposition, so I have to be careful.

But I think it set us back in terms of individuals wanting to get out there, serving their country, do something that's really chal-

lenging. I think in the Coast Guard, what we suffer from most is exposure. People don't necessarily know who we are, especially young people who want, you know, a challenging and rewarding career in the United States military. We're getting after that. We've got a new campaign. We're opening up new recruiting offices. We're expanding our recruiting capacity by 38 percent. The numbers are starting to come back. So, by early indications, we're having some successes.

Mr. CRANE. So, you think that COVID is the main reason that the military is having its recruiting issues?

Mr. GAUTIER. I'm an optimist, sir. You hear these things about the eligibility because of weight and pharmaceuticals and stuff is lower in the average young population, that there isn't this propensity to serve. I hardly disagree. I think there are a lot of great young Americans out there who just don't know about the Coast Guard. That if they knew that we are law enforcement, that we do we're military, that we clean up the environment, that we serve the American people, I think, you know, we'll have a lot more folks coming in.

Mr. CRANE. Thanks, Admiral. To follow up on that, do you think it might have anything to do with what you regularly hear as being described as some of the wokeness within the military, like CRT training, DEI training, drag shows on base, things like that? Do you think that has anything to do with it? It is kind-of a loss of the focus of what the military is supposed to be about.

Mr. GAUTIER. You know, I just don't see that in the United States Coast Guard what you're referring to. Our work force is the best work force that I've seen in my 36-year career. The people who are in the Coast Guard today are better than ever before. A lot of them have college educations. A lot of them have had professional careers that want to do something different and better and that come to us. So, I don't think so.

Mr. CRANE. You haven't seen any of that?

Mr. GAUTIER. No.

Mr. CRANE. You haven't seen a change in the culture of the military? How long have you been in, Admiral?

Mr. GAUTIER. Thirty-seven years.

Mr. CRANE. With all due respect, I find that hard to believe, sir. What about vaccine mandates, sir? You know that we lost about 30,000 active-duty service members that refused to take the vaccine that are now being asked if they want to come back into the service? What do you think about that?

Mr. GAUTIER. We welcome them back.

Mr. CRANE. Yes, I know, but do you think that has anything to do with recruitment efforts? The military can be a pretty dangerous place to work, right, Admiral?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, absolutely.

Mr. CRANE. When I left the military, sir, I was an E6, and I went into some of the most dangerous environments in the world being in Special Forces. It was very easy for me to go into some of those spots knowing that my leadership actually cared about my well-being. But when service members, regardless of what whether they are in the Marines, Coast Guard, Navy, et cetera, when they don't believe that their leadership is motivated by their well-being, but

they are just, in the case of the vaccines, making them take experimental vaccines, knowing that the survivability rates were about 99.9 percent and they didn't see the need for it, that is a problem. It makes some of these young individuals question whether or not their welfare is going to be looked after, whether or not they are going to start a family and set down roots in a community and then be forced out for something like that. Do you think that has anything to do with the recruiting problem?

Mr. GAUTIER. Congressman, so you've been there, right?

Mr. CRANE. Yes.

Mr. GAUTIER. Serving in really difficult situations. You know, to your point, I know that Admiral Fagan, Master Chief Petty Officer Jones, the senior leadership team, we feel like we need to earn the respect of our junior work force every single day, and we work hard to earn that respect by supporting them in their endeavors.

Mr. CRANE. Do you think it was a mistake to force that many service members out because they wouldn't take an experimental vaccine?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, I——

Mr. CRANE. I know you got to be careful.

Mr. GAUTIER [continuing]. I don't have the luxury of being afforded an opinion on that, sir.

Mr. CRANE. I understand. Thank you. I yield back, Mr. Chairman.

Chairman GREEN. The gentleman yields. I want to thank the witnesses for being here and want to recognize our Ranking Member designee today for her closing comments. So, you are going to do the questions too? OK. The gentlelady from New York would like to take her 5 minutes of questioning too. So, please go ahead.

Ms. CLARKE. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. I thank our witnesses for both their service and testimony here today. Unfortunately, I had a very conflicting hearing at the same time, so I missed some of your testimony, and I hope that my questions will not be repetitive. The climate is clearly changing in the Arctic, which is driving many of the challenges we are seeing today. In order for the Coast Guard to plan appropriately for the years and decades ahead, the service must maintain an understanding of climate change and what impact it will have on ice coverage and sea levels in the Arctic. So, Admiral, how does the Coast Guard consider the predicted impacts of climate change when developing its plans and strategies, including planning for shore infrastructure projects, determining asset and personnel requirements, and designing cutters?

Mr. GAUTIER. Yes, thanks, Congresswoman. So, we think in terms of climate change in three different ways. The first, as you're alluding to, is we need to build resilience into our own Coast Guard assets, not just our cutter operations, but even more so on our shore infrastructure resilience. So, you know, as we do things like recapitalize piers to homeport a couple of offshore patrol cutters in Kodiak, we build those piers to resilient standards that incorporate the potential for more and severe storms and for raising sea levels.

The second thing that we do is we need to be prepared to respond more frequently to climate-driven disasters. We know that coastal erosion is just accelerating at an alarming rate in Alaska.

Alaska got hit by a typhoon, typhoon Merbok, last year, and we were a first responder in that element.

Then the third thing is we're actually a regulator. So, under the leadership of Secretary Kerry and the State Department team, the Coast Guard negotiated international maritime organization that by 2050, international deep draft shipping needs to be at zero carbon emission.

Ms. CLARKE. What sources does the Coast Guard rely on to inform its understanding of the predicted impacts of climate change?

Mr. GAUTIER. Well, we work very closely with the experts. Certainly, the National Oceanographic and Atmospheric Administration and the National Weather Service give us great predictions. FEMA is just, first and foremost in terms of just general resiliency against disasters. We're a close partner with FEMA and DHS in that regard.

Ms. CLARKE. Very well. Let me again thank you all for all of your service, your hard work, your dedication, and your testimony here today. With that, Mr. Chairman, I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. Gentlady yields. I now recognize the gentlady for her closing remarks.

Ms. CLARKE. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I am making these remarks on behalf of our Ranking Member, Mr. Thompson. I want to thank our witnesses for sharing their expertise with us this morning. It has been a productive discussion and it is clear there is bipartisan interest in ensuring the Coast Guard, DHS, and their partners are empowered and resourced to carry out their security missions in the Arctic effectively.

The climate is changing and its impacts on the Arctic will be profound. To those who may question whether climate change is real or say it is not necessary to understand what is causing climate change to deal with its impacts, I say this, follow the facts, follow the science.

We must understand how the climate will continue to change in the Arctic in order to prepare for the opportunities and challenges that are hurtling our way. It is clear that Russia and China will continue to grow their presence in the Arctic and that maritime activity will continue to increase due to opportunities for shipping, tourism, fishing, and energy exploration. The United States must continue to protect its interests in the region by supporting adherence to a rules-based international order. The State Department's diplomatic efforts are critical and I thank the GAO for its work in highlighting successes of those efforts and opportunities to improve.

I hope the Senate will act quickly to confirm our first ambassador-at-large for the Arctic region, which will represent an important milestone in elevating our strategic focus on the Arctic. As we advance our work in the region, we must do so in close consultation with Native Tribes and communities. They experience the effects of changing environment and increased activity first-hand and their perspectives are invaluable. Enhancing the Coast Guard's operational capabilities is also key to protecting U.S. sovereignty in the Arctic. I, being him, look forward to working with members of both parties to help keep the Coast Guard's icebreaker acquisition efforts on track and building toward the future. Mr. Chairman, I, being him, am glad to see our committee continuing to examine

homeland security issues in the Arctic, building upon our efforts in past Congresses. I thank you for convening today's hearing, and I yield back.

Chairman GREEN. The gentlelady yields. I want to thank our Members for their participation in today's hearing and of course, thank our witnesses for their testimony and for taking the answers—and providing answers to the Members' questions. One last quick question, Admiral Gautier, and I think you are going to be rooting for Navy December 9, is that correct? Or are you going to stay out of that one?

Mr. GAUTIER. West Point grad, I suspect? So, I guess that means Army this time.

Chairman GREEN. I should have asked you that at the beginning of the hearing. Well, again, thank you all for being here. I really appreciate your candor on this issue.

It is pretty easy to see the issues that are before us. Definitively, the United States is an Arctic country. We are an Arctic nation. What happens in the Arctic region has a direct impact on America's citizens and the overall well-being of our country. The Arctic has been a facilitator of commerce for the United States for decades, if not centuries. The bountiful natural resources in Alaska and the Arctic region, from fish to oil to gas remain critical economic drivers in the United States and help us not only provide for the needs of our population, but also to provide other countries around the world a better alternative to doing business with dictatorships and tyrannical regimes.

Also, the Arctic is critical to securing the United States homeland, and the Arctic is the first line of defense against nation-state threats. I am concerned about the threats from the PRC and Russia, two adversarial states that have repeatedly attempted to undermine the rules-based international order promoted by the United States and our allies abroad. With Russia's increased militarization of the Arctic and the PRC's increased interest and presence in the Arctic, it is critical that we maintain an effective operational presence in the Arctic region to protect the U.S. homeland from aggression from two of our most significant adversaries.

The United States and its Arctic partners promote the rules-based international order and ensure that other nation-states respect and adhere to that vision of sovereignty. The United States participation in the Arctic Council and the Coast Guard's engagement with partner nations in the Arctic Coast Guard Forum helps our country uphold international maritime laws and norms and helps us hold bad actors such as Russia and the PRC accountable for breaches to these norms.

U.S. policy moving forward should be focused on advancing our competitive advantages in the region and working with our partners and allies to further our shared objectives, while at the same time pushing back against the efforts of our greatest adversaries to seize another foothold in a key region in pursuit of their destabilizing ambitions. This committee, therefore, must ensure that our Government appropriately prioritizes the Arctic region in carrying out its Constitutional duties.

I want to thank you all again for your participation in today's hearing, and I hope we can continue to find ways that the com-

mittee can uphold the Constitutional values, our Constitutional values in the Arctic and support the organizations tasked by our Government to do just that.

The Members of the committee may have some additional questions for the witnesses, and we should ask the witnesses to respond to those in writing. Pursuant to a Rule VII(D), the hearing record will be held open for 10 days for those if you get written questions. Without objection, the committee is adjourned.

[Whereupon, at 12:33 p.m., the committee was adjourned.]

APPENDIX

STATEMENT OF SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

WEDNESDAY, NOVEMBER 29, 2023

Chairman Green and Ranking Member Thompson thank you for convening this hearing. As a lifelong Alaskan, I have spent over 20 years in Congress working to highlight the importance of the Arctic and Alaska to our Nation. Alaska, the second-youngest State, gives the United States the privilege, opportunity, and responsibility of being an Arctic Nation. Over the years, our Nation's attention and the perceived importance of the Arctic has fluctuated, and at times, the Arctic has been treated as a buzzword that eventually fades away from the forefront of the National conscience and of our policymakers.

I believe those days are over. The "Arctic Moment" has come and gone, and we are looking now at what the "Arctic Century" looks like. Most recently, it took a flotilla of Chinese and Russian warships weaving in and out of our territorial waters off Alaska and a Chinese spy balloon invading our National airspace through Alaska for our military leaders and policymakers in Washington to remember Billy Mitchell's prescient words, "I believe that in the future, whoever controls Alaska controls the world. I think it is the most strategic place in the world."

Yet, there is so much more value to Alaska and the Arctic than just controlling it. To realize the National security, diplomatic, and economic (critical minerals, fossil fuels) benefits for our country and for our allies from the Arctic, this Congress and administration must prioritize infrastructure investments both in the commercial and National defense spaces.

Over the last decade, Congress and the Federal bureaucracy have produced reams of reports discussing the strategic importance of the Arctic. Those reports are full of words about planning and multi-agency coordination but rarely, if at all, specifically discuss the investments required to realize those plans or ambitions. In fact, in the U.S. Coast Guard's recently-released "Arctic Strategic Outlook Implementation Plan," the word "budgetary" appears once in 28 pages. From my perspective, there cannot be an honest National "Arctic Strategy" without the commensurate level of operational capacity. That requires our agencies to prioritize Arctic-related budgetary requests and Congress to prioritize investments in our Coast Guard, Army Corps of Engineers, and Arctic DOD capabilities, just to name a few.

For example, in the maritime context, the Nation's most northern deep-water ice-free port near the Bering Sea is in Dutch Harbor, Alaska, which has no year-round military presence or Coast Guard cutter presence. Dutch Harbor is 763 nautical miles from Coast Guard Base Kodiak, which is the largest Coast Guard base in the world. Base Kodiak is 1,415 nautical miles away from Nome, Alaska where the Nation's first deep draft Arctic port is under development. If there is an incident in the Arctic and a U.S. surface asset isn't already in the area, our Nation's response time is measured in days, not hours.

For over a decade, the Alaska Delegation has been working to build our Nation's first Arctic Deep Draft Port in Nome, Alaska so that it may accommodate Coast Guard vessels and serve as a strategic hub for commerce, operational persistence, and emergency response. It is a vital project for the future of U.S. Arctic capability. Yet, the reality is that the project has only received \$250 million dollars in Federal funding to date, from the Army Corps Civil Works budget as a result of the funding provided in the Infrastructure Investment & Jobs Act (IIJA). Completing the Port of Nome will require significant additional Federal investment, and I hope I can count on the Members of CHS on both sides of the dais to be there.

Additionally, in the U.S. Arctic, our Nation continues to lean more and more on the United States Coast Guard. The Coast Guard men and women in District 17 are part of the fabric of our Alaskan communities, and go above and beyond to secure our Nation and provide invaluable services such as search and rescue. From

a surface asset force projection standpoint, it is the Coast Guard that is on the front lines in the Arctic and Alaska, protecting our fisheries, facilitating the flow of commerce, and upholding the international rules-based order. As problems continue to plague the surface acquisitions vital to safety and security in the region, namely the Polar Security Cutter and Offshore Patrol Cutter programs, ensuring there is a stop-gap solution to maintain a consistent U.S. Arctic presence is becoming increasingly dire.

For years, Senator Sullivan and I have pointed to the lack of U.S. icebreaking capability as a harbinger of neglect of our Nation's Arctic capabilities. That is why I have continued to advocate for an interim solution via a Commercially Available Icebreaker (CIB) to bridge the gap until the first Polar Security Cutter arrives, hopefully before the end of this decade. As a Congress, we are going to need to continue to invest in the PSC program but if we want to improve our icebreaking capability in the near term, we must preserve the funding for the CIB that is in both the fiscal year 2024 House and Senate Homeland Security appropriations bills.

As a Nation, we cannot look at these investments as a one-off or zero-sum. New hulls and ports are helpful but mean little if the Coast Guard doesn't have the manpower to crew these new assets or a place to homeport them. This leads me to mention that investing in the Coast Guard's human capital and shoreside infrastructure needs are as equally important as new hulls. Without housing, child care, or new piers in Alaska, new hulls will be stationed hundreds or thousands of miles away from this vital area of responsibility. In 2021, the IIJA provided the Coast Guard with \$429 million to address what was a decades-long backlog in shoreside infrastructure funding needs. Two-hundred twenty-seven-point-five million dollars of that was allocated for Alaska to make sure we are ready to homeport vessels scheduled for delivery. Unfortunately, the momentum on this front has stalled, as this year's Homeland Security Appropriation bills did not originally fund the Coast Guard's request for \$42 million to finish the FRC homeporting station in Seward. This threatens to delay the availability of an FRC with quick access to the Gulf of Alaska. Until we find a way to adequately resource the Coast Guard, our country will struggle to meet the strategic opportunities and mitigate threats in the U.S. Arctic.

As policymakers in Washington, we must continue to increase our investments in our Nation's Arctic infrastructure. All of the rhetoric in the world about the Arctic's importance to the strategic interests of the United States must translate into sustained National investments.

Thank you for the opportunity to provide a testimony and for the committee's interest in this critical area.

